

TREE OF LIFE

TREE OF LIFE

SYMBOL OF GOD'S SPIRIT IN EDEN, PARADISE,
AND THE NEW JERUSALEM

THE RESTORATION SERIES
BOOK 2

DR. TIM JAMES



Tree of Life: Symbol of God's Spirit in Eden, Paradise, and the New Jerusalem

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Tree of Life

*A symbol of the Holy Spirit's
presence and the
restoration of all things.
(Acts 3:21)*

ABSTRACT

The Tree of Life traces the most enduring symbol of God's presence from Eden to New Jerusalem and is mentioned by Jesus as being present in the "Paradise of God."

Dr. Tim James explores how this divine Tree connects creation, redemption, resurrection, and eternity, revealing God's plan to dwell among His people.

This book is rich in theology and grounded in Scripture.

Tree of Life is a companion to *Presuppositions* and the other titles in The Restoration Series — reclaiming the gospel's full story.

PREFACE: A CALL TO RESTORATION

Presuppositions was the first volume in the series to be released.

It speaks to those frustrated by contradiction and confusion—to those longing for the Bible to make sense again, as one coherent story from Genesis to Revelation.

Presuppositions challenges long-held assumptions. Its aim is realignment: to help restore confidence in God's redemptive plan by removing what clouds it.

This book, *Tree of Life*, is intended for serious students of Scripture, teachers, pastors, seekers, and anyone willing to examine their teachings critically.

You may find that some ideas handed down by family, tradition, or even from the pulpit differ from what the biblical authors originally intended. When you encounter a new idea, listen for the soft affirmation of the Holy Spirit.

And if you come across a statement you find objectionable, pause. Test it.

Conduct your own study. Compare translations. Use the resources listed at the back of this book.

Each chapter concludes with reflection questions, designed to reinforce key themes and encourage honest self-examination.

As we turn to the *Restoration Series* overview, I invite you to see how *Tree of Life* fits within the larger framework of God's redemptive plan. This series unfolds the biblical themes that unite Eden to the New Jerusalem, tracing God's covenant faithfulness and His promise of ultimate restoration.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

<i>Prologue</i>	xi
<i>Purpose and Scope</i>	xiii
<i>The Biblical Location of the Tree of Life:</i>	xvii
<i>The Two Families of Elohim: elohim + Humans</i>	xix
Methodology	1
Foreword	3
Adam Communes With God While Eve Faces Temptation	7
Left blank on purpose.	8
1. The Mountain of God	9
<i>Eden, Zion, and Divine Council Restoration</i>	
2. In the Midst of the Garden	19
<i>Edenic Altitude and Sacred Assembly</i>	
“The Fall”	31
Left blank on purpose.	32
3. The Fall, the Guardian, and the Flaming Sword	33
<i>Exile from the Summit and the Shifting Geography of Glory</i>	
4. The Sacred Geography of Eden	41
<i>From Summit to Soil: and the Tree that Spanned the Divide.</i>	
5. Where is Sheol?	45
<i>The Subterranean Geography of the Afterlife</i>	
7 Core Truths Revealed in Luke 16:19-31	61
Where Did Jesus Go When He Died?	63
Left blank on purpose.	65
Left blank on purpose.	68
6. Jesus Descended Into Paradise	69
<i>What Happened Between the Cross and the Resurrection</i>	
Left blank on purpose.	78
7. The Blessed Hope is Resurrection	79
<i>The Tree of Life’s Presence in Sheol’s Paradise: The Anchor of Hope</i>	
Left blank on purpose.	84
8. The Righteous Dead and the Presence of the Tree	85
<i>Sheol’s Paradise, Where the Righteous Dead Await the Resurrection</i>	
Left blank on purpose.	92

9. Sheol's Secrets and the Cosmic Battle	93
<i>The Tree's Ever-Present Witness and the River of Life</i>	
Left blank on purpose.	97
Left blank on purpose.	98
10. The Tree of Life and the Millennial Kingdom	99
<i>The Garden Restored on Earth</i>	
Left blank on purpose.	104
11. Refuting Popular Errors	105
<i>The Tree, the Rapture, and the Return of the King</i>	
12. The Triumph of Resurrection	109
<i>The Tree's Witness and the Convergence of Spirit and Flesh</i>	
13. The King's Call to Muster — The Last Trumpet	117
<i>The Day of The Lord's Triumphant Trumpet</i>	
14. The Tree's Life-giving Fruit — The Final Harvest	123
<i>A Celebration of Restoration and Healing</i>	
Left blank on purpose.	130
15. Life Immortal	131
<i>Glorified Saints, Resurrection, and Eternal Union</i>	
16. The Tree in the Age to Come	135
<i>New Jerusalem and Eden Restored</i>	
Appendix A - Scripture List	141
Appendix B - Luke 16:19-31 Verse-by-Verse Study	143
Appendix C - Deeper Study: Sheol, Resurrection, First Resurrection	147
Appendix D - The UP/DN Scriptural Journey of the Dead	153
Appendix E - The Temple in God's Abode	157
Reading & Research Guide	161
Glossary of Key Biblical Terms	163
Introduction to Bible Linguistics	165
Epilogue	167
 <i>About the Author</i>	 169
<i>Afterword</i>	171

PROLOGUE

Tree of Life

In Scripture, the **Tree of Life** is a living symbol of God's Holy Spirit — His *Shekhinah* Glory. In man's hour of need — **God's Holy Spirit** is always available.

Yes, God (Genesis 3:15) provided our Redeemer.

*He also gifted us: "Our Protective Overseer," "The Helper of Pentecost,"
"The Tree of Life"
— His Holy Spirit.*

Supporting Verses

Psalm 30:10 — *“Hear, O Lord, and be merciful to me! O Lord, be my helper!”*

Psalm 54:4 — *“Behold, God is my helper; the Lord is the upholder of my life.”*

Psalm 118:7 — *“The Lord is on my side as my helper; I shall look in triumph on those who hate me.”*

John 14:26-27 — *“but the Helper, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, He will teach you all things and bring to your remembrance all that I have said to you. Peace I leave with you;...Let not your hearts be troubled, neither let them be afraid.”*

Hebrews 13:6 — *“The Lord is my helper; I will not fear; what can man do to me?”*

PURPOSE AND SCOPE

Tree of Life continues the mission of *Presuppositions* — to recover the biblical worldview and restore the coherence of God's redemptive plan.

In this volume, we narrow the focus of our lens. We trace one divine symbol across the ages: the Tree of Life.

Often overlooked or allegorized, this Tree is far more than a poetic metaphor. Scripture presents it as a real, living fixture in Eden, in Paradise, and the eternal world to come. Its presence signifies God's Spirit, His provision, and His promise of eternal life.

This book follows the Tree's journey — from the Garden, to its mysterious place in Sheol's Paradise, to its reappearance in the New Jerusalem. Along the way, it addresses themes of rebellion, restoration, resurrection, and glory.

Those who've read *Presuppositions* will recognize familiar theological ground. But this book stands on its own — an invitation to recover the gospel's whole arc by rediscovering the Tree of Life.

THEMATIC OVERVIEW

This book traces the Tree through Scripture. From Eden to Paradise to the New Jerusalem, the Tree of Life is the enduring symbol of God's presence, provision, and promise.

Discover how this Tree *is* the Spirit of God — nourishing the righteous and healing the nations.

“Then the angel showed me the river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb through the middle of the street of the city; also, on either side of the river, the Tree of Life with its twelve kinds of fruit, yielding its fruit each month. The leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations.”

— **Revelation 22:1-2**



THE BIBLICAL LOCATION OF THE TREE OF LIFE:

1. The Garden of Eden
2. Sheol's Paradise
3. New Jerusalem

Genesis 2:9

“...the tree of life was in the midst of the garden...”

Revelation 2:7

“...to the one who overcomes, I will grant to eat of the tree of life, which is in the Paradise of God.

Revelation 22:2

“...on either side of the river, the tree of life... yielding its fruit each month...”



THE TWO FAMILIES OF ELOHIM: ELOHIM + HUMANS

This image depicts a majestic and symbolic scene illustrating God's household. At the top center, God (Elohim) is enthroned in radiant light, surrounded by angelic beings — His divine council — arranged in reverent formation. These spiritual beings reflect hierarchy and worship, evoking passages like:

“God has taken His place in the divine council; in the midst of the gods He holds judgment.”

— *Psalms 82:1*

“Let the heavens praise your wonders, O LORD, your faithfulness in the assembly of the holy ones!”

— *Psalms 89:5-6*

“Now there was a day when the sons of God came to present themselves before the LORD...”

— *Job 1:6*

Beneath the throne, a group of glorified human figures stands in humble awe. These represent the redeemed human family — saints,

patriarchs, and faithful believers who serve God's purposes (Cf. *Daniel 7:27, Revelation 22:5*).

This visual theology affirms the **cosmic courtroom motif**: God is not alone in the spiritual realm. He presides as the Most High over both angelic and human participants in His divine administration.

METHODOLOGY

This study draws on interlinear tools such as BibleHub, Blue Letter Bible, and Logos Bible Software.

- **Textual integrity** means prioritizing Scripture, allowing the biblical text to speak for itself rather than forcing it into inherited frameworks.
- **Linguistic accuracy** necessitates visiting the original Hebrew, Greek, and Aramaic languages to correct mistranslations.
- **Theological coherence** refers to reading the Bible as the original authors intended it to be understood.

FOREWORD

The Plural Language in Genesis

Genesis 1:26 — “Then God said, ‘Let us make man in our image, after our likeness...”

Genesis 3:22 — “Behold, the man has become like one of us, in knowing good and evil...”

These two verses are often misinterpreted as references to the concept of the Trinity. However, a deeper perspective reveals that the plural pronouns reflect a *divine assembly* — a heavenly court of “sons of God” spiritual beings that surround and serve Yahweh.

The Divine Council in Action

Psalms 82:1 – “*God (Elohim) has taken His place in the divine council; in the midst of the gods (elohim) He holds judgment.*”

This passage affirms that God presides as the Most High over both the heavenly host and the redeemed human family.

1 Kings 22:19 – *“I saw the Lord sitting on His throne, and all the host of heaven standing beside Him... And the Lord said, ‘Who will entice Ahab?’”*

This is a **heavenly deliberation**, where lesser elohim are invited to speak, although God alone decrees the outcome.

Job 1:6 – *“Now there was a day when the sons of God (bene ha’elohim) came to present themselves before the Lord, and Satan also came among them.”*

Job 38:7 – *“...when the morning stars sang together and all the sons of God shouted for joy?”*

The New Testament Echo

Hebrews 1:14 — *“Are they not all ministering spirits sent out to serve for the sake of those who are to inherit salvation?”*

NOTE: Only humans *can benefit from salvation*. Angels cannot.

Revelation 4-5 — *“[1] ‘Come up here, and I will show you what must take place after this... [2] At once I was in the Spirit, and behold, a throne stood in heaven, with one seated on the throne.’”*

John’s vision of God’s heavenly throne room reveals a divine council — the 24 elders and angelic hosts. These are not human beings but part of God’s divine order, distinct from the redeemed human family.



ADAM COMMUNES WITH GOD WHILE EVE FACES TEMPTATION

The story of the Tree of Life begins in Eden — a place of divine communion, temptation, and choice. The opening chapter unveils this setting through Scripture's lens, interwoven with the powerful imagery of Adam's communion and Eve's early encounter.

Let these images guide your heart into the garden as we explore the sacred geography of God's original earthly dwelling place.

THE MOUNTAIN OF GOD

EDEN, ZION, AND DIVINE COUNCIL RESTORATION

“The Tree of Life was in the midst of the garden.”

— Genesis 2:9b

[8] “And the LORD God planted a garden in Eden, in the east, and there He put the man whom He had formed. [9] And out of the ground the LORD God made to spring up every tree that is pleasant to the sight and good for food. The tree of life was in the midst of the garden, and the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. [10] A river flowed out of Eden to water the garden,...”

—Genesis 2:8-10

Eden Was at the Sloping Base of “The Holy Mountain of God.”

Ezekiel speaks of Eden as “the holy mountain of God” in a lament over “the King of Tyre.” ...

[13] “You were in Eden, the garden of God; ... [14] You were an anointed guardian cherub. I placed you...on the holy mountain of God; in the midst of the stones of fire you walked. [15] Unrighteousness was found in you. [16] In

the abundance of your deceptions, you were filled with violence...and you sinned; so I cast you as a profane thing from the mountain of God... “

— Ezekiel 28:13-16

In ancient Near Eastern thought, **the divine presence was always associated with mountaintops** — high places where heaven and earth meet.

Dr. Michael Heiser explained it this way:

“The biblical writers thought of Eden as an abode of God — His holy mountain. It was the original temple, the original throne room. Adam was placed there to serve as priest, guardian, and representative.”

— Unseen Realm, Ch. 3

Eden was far more than a paradise — it was the cosmic headquarters of divine administration.

From Eden to Paradise to New Jerusalem

The geography of God’s presence moves in **five great stages**:

1. **Eden** — *where heaven and earth were one, and God walked with man. As was Eden, the new Jerusalem (cf. Revelation 21-22) will also be here on the earth.*
2. **Paradise (Sheol)** — *the spiritual Eden-like place of waiting for the righteous dead — while awaiting resurrection back to the surface of the earth.*
3. **Sinai** — *the mountain of covenant, fire, and divine descent.*
4. **Zion** — *the temple mount, a.k.a. “mount of assembly,” where the name of the Lord will dwell among His people for eternity.*
5. **New Jerusalem** — *the eternal abode of the righteous — here, on the new earth, surrounded by the new heavens.*

Each stage draws the divine presence closer to its ultimate convergence — the reunion of “heaven and earth.”

Psalm 48 links Zion directly to Eden’s legacy...

“Great is the LORD and greatly to be praised in the city of our God! His holy mountain, [2] beautiful in elevation, is the joy of all the earth, Mount Zion, in the far north, the city of the great King.”

— **Psalm 48:1-2**

This echoes Isaiah 14’s description of divine heights. The “far north” (Heb. *tsaphon*) symbolizes **cosmic height** — the throne of God among the divine council.

Heiser noted:

“In Israelite thinking, Zion is the theological successor to Eden. It will be the new mount of assembly — the location of God’s throne among His people.”

— **NB-66: Psalm 48**

“[4] For behold, the kings assembled; they came on together. [8] As we have heard, so have we seen in the city of the LORD of hosts, in the city of our God, which God will establish forever. Selah”

— **Psalm 48:4-8**

That city is the new Jerusalem.

The Divine Council Restored

Eden was not just the place of God’s presence — it was the place of His **divine council** — the “sons of God” (*bene elohim*) gathered there. And they still do. What we’ve been taught about Heaven being some ethereal netherworld is ill-conceived. It’s right here, but we humans can’t see it.

The serpent's (Heb. *nahas* or *nahash*) rebellion was an attempted **coup** in God's administration.

"You were on the holy mountain of God; in the midst of the stones of fire you walked... till unrighteousness was found in you."

— **Ezekiel 28:14-15**

That rebellion fractured the harmony of the divine council — in both the heavenward and earthward sides of the veil.

When Christ ascended (Daniel 7:13-14) and was given the kingdom (the Kingdom of God is on the earth), the planning for its future *restoration* earnestly began.

Yes, disembodied righteous humans have been "saved" by the blood of Christ. In the future, upon our resurrection and "being changed," we will be **elevated** — not relocated to Heaven, but in stature and service as co-heirs participating in King Jesus' restoration and government of this planet. This is what is referred to as Christ's Millennial Reign.

"Do you not know that we are to judge angels? How much more, then, matters pertaining to this life!"

— **1 Corinthians 6:3**

This verse is part of Paul's rebuke to the Corinthian believers for taking disputes before secular courts rather than resolving them within the church.

This ties back to God's New Covenant — Jesus' covenantal sacrifice for salvation...

[22] *"You have come to Mount Zion... to the city of God — the living Jerusalem. ... [23] and to the assembly of the firstborn, having been enrolled (name in the book of life) in the heavens... and to God, the judge of all,*

and to the spirits of the righteous having been perfected, and of a new covenant, to Jesus, and to the blood... ”

— **Hebrews 12:22-24**

What is “the assembly of the firstborn?”

The word “firstborn” aligns with inheritance — those who share in the inheritance of the resurrected Christ...

[16] “The Spirit Himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God, [17] and if children, then heirs—heirs of God and fellow heirs with Christ, provided we suffer with Him so that we may also be glorified with Him.”

— **Romans 8:16-17**

“And He is the head of the body, the church, He is the beginning, the firstborn from the dead...”

— **Colossians 1:18**

What Christians Believe

First, Christians believe that Jesus’ shed blood and death have the power to forgive sins (“Grace”). Second, Christians understand that “Firstborn from the dead” (a.k.a. “Firstfruit”) refers to Jesus’ resurrection from Sheol’s Paradise back to the surface of the earth. Where some English translations say that Jesus descended into Sheol, it does not mean that He descended into Hades (the side of punishing pain and suffering), but rather to Paradise (the side of reward and comfort). Several translations get that wrong. Thus, He overcame death. And that was the encouraging message Jesus gave to all those righteous He visited in Paradise: they, too, will be resurrected back to the surface to live and reign with Him for “1,000 years.” When? On the Day of the Lord.

What Does the Future Hold for the Unrighteous Dead?

The unrighteous spirits in Hades are already eternally damned — they have no hope for redemption. And, of course, there is no pathway for redemption of “fallen angels” since they have no soul.

What Happens at the Resurrection?

Resurrection means being delivered back to the surface of the earth — in new, glorified, immortal bodies, like Jesus’:

3 [2] “Beloved, we are God’s children now, and what we will be has not yet appeared; but we know that when He appears we shall see Him as He is.”

— 1 John 3:2

3 [20] “...from it (heaven) we await a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ, [21] who will transform our lowly body to be like His glorious body...”

— Philippians 3:20

2 [13] “waiting for our blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ, [14] who gave Himself for us to redeem us from all lawlessness and to purify for Himself a people for His own possession who are zealous for good works.”

— Titus 2:13-14

What is the Truth About Jesus’ Second Coming?

Our blessed hope is to see King Jesus and His angelic armies descending from their heavenly abode toward the earth. The righteous dead in Christ will be resurrected, and the righteous living in Christ will be “changed”/transformed. Together, we will rise from the surface of the earth to meet our King in the air. In Greek, the terms are *harpazo*: rise up; *apantesis*: to meet Him in the air, *episunagoge*: to be gathered to Him, and *parousia*: to return to the earth with Him (AEP). This is not a secretive pre-tribulation rapture, as has been erroneously taught in the USA since the mid-1800s (the Darby-Scofield fallacy). What truthfully takes place is precisely what was

foreshadowed on the original Palm Sunday. Jesus approached riding a donkey; the crowd saw Him and ran out to greet Him, and then they paraded with Him back into Jerusalem. All the righteous of all time, all the way back to the garden of Eden, will be resurrected back to the surface of the planet, where we will live and reign with Christ during the millennium. So, when does that reign begin? On the day of the Lord.

“Blessed and holy is the one who shares in the first resurrection!”

— **Revelation 20:6**

What does it mean, “having been enrolled in the heavens”?

This refers to the righteous whose names are written in the Lamb’s book of life — denoting legal citizenship in the kingdom to come.

“...our citizenship is in heaven, and from it we await a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ, [21] Who will transform our lowly body to be like His glorious body...”

— **Philippians 3:20-21**

NOTE: By “our citizenship is in heaven,” it does not mean that *we* are citizens of heaven — God’s heavenly abode. It means that we are heirs *with* Jesus of His kingdom on the earth. Our “citizenship” is linked with and dependent upon our relationship with Jesus. And it is He who is currently seated on God’s heavenly throne.

10 [20] “rejoice that your names are written in heaven.”

— **Luke 10:20**

NOTE: God’s book of life is currently in His possession in “heaven,” our names are written “in heaven.” This does not mean that we will one day reside in the heavenlies — which is reserved for Elohim and his elohim.

“Enrolled” is Greek *apographō* — a term denoting a census or

registry. Elohim members of God's divine council keep records in "the books."

The implication is one of **pre-appointed identity and belonging** — predicated on righteousness and union with Christ.

Now, Back to The Mountain of God and the new Jerusalem

"By its light will the nations walk, and the kings of the earth will bring their glory into it..."

— **Revelation 21:24-27**

NOTE: Christ is THE KING. But the righteous who are resurrected and "changed" will be Christ's assistants in governing. That's what "we will rule and reign with Him" means by *kings of the earth*.

At the end of the "1,000 years," Elohim (YHWH) Most High will deliver the new Jerusalem to the restored earth — it having been restored to its original Edenic condition. And this is the last word the Bible speaks about the Tree of Life.

The Tree Near the Summit

The Tree of Life stood amid the Garden of Eden, on the Mountain of God. The garden was a place of divine proximity. The Tree of Life, representing God's Spirit, offered eternal life. And when I connect Adam to the priesthood, I mean that Adam had unmediated access to God.

Looking into the future — to the new Jerusalem, it will be much the same then, as it was in the garden — the Tree of Life will be there...

"Then the angel showed me the river of the water of life... on either side of the river, the tree of life... the leaves of the tree are for the healing of the nations."

— **Revelation 22:1-2**

Once Christ returns and righteous humanity helps Him make all things new again, the New Jerusalem will **descend** to earth.

We don't go up — it **comes down**—the final and eternal **Mount Zion**.

Imagine how great that will be, enjoying eternity in the presence of our Creator God, in the new Jerusalem.

But Wait, There's More To The Story

As the movie line hinted, “we need to go back to the past to understand the future.” There's much more to the story we have yet to cover. So, let's journey back to the garden and delve a little deeper. What, exactly, is “in the midst” of that garden?



Reflect & Discuss

1. How does the concept of Eden as “the Holy Mountain of God” challenge or expand your understanding of Eden’s original role in God’s plan? (*Hint: Think about Ezekiel’s imagery and how it connects to the presence of God and the Divine Council.*)
2. What do you think the vertical flow of divine geography (Eden → Paradise → New Jerusalem) tells us about God’s plan for His creation? (*Consider the significance of mountains, summits, and how God’s presence is seen to “descend” rather than humans going up.*)
3. Why do you think God chose to reveal Himself on mountains throughout Scripture — from Eden to Sinai to Zion? (*Reflect on the symbolism of “high places” as places of divine encounter.*)
4. How does the idea of the Tree of Life as both a literal and spiritual symbol impact your view of eternal life in Christ? (*Explore how Revelation’s Tree of Life imagery echoes Eden’s original promise.*)

IN THE MIDST OF THE GARDEN

EDENIC ALTITUDE AND SACRED ASSEMBLY

MOUNTAIN THEOLOGY

Eden Was Not Just a Garden — It Was a Mountain.

“You were in Eden, the garden of God... You were on the holy mountain of God.”

— Ezekiel 28:13-14

Scripture calls it a *mountain* — a holy elevation — a place where the divine and the earthly realms overlapped — visibly.

From the earliest days of civilization, people seemed to know: **the gods live up there.**

Across ancient cultures, mountains were not merely majestic — they were sacred. In Mesopotamia, humans built ziggurats to mimic divine heights, seeking to reach the heavens from below. In Canaanite religion, Baal ruled from Mount Zaphon, the seat of storm and sky.

Even outside the Bible, cultures from Babylon to Mesoamerica constructed their temples at the point where the earth met the sky. In fact, that's what the Tower of Babel was all about.

This widespread instinct was far more than superstition. It was a **theological echo** of Eden—the first and highest place where God dwelt with humanity. Before Sinai, before Zion, before Olympus... there was the holy mountain of God.

From the very beginning, **God dwelt in high places**:

- He descended upon **Mount Sinai** in thunder and fire.
- He challenged Baal above **Mount Carmel**.
- He transfigured His Son on **Mount Hermon**. (We will revisit Mount Hermon elsewhere in The Restoration Series.)
- And, God chose **Mount Zion** to place David's throne.

Every sacred summit is a shadow of Eden — and a prophecy that Mount Zion will one day be restored.

God's Purpose: Image-Bearing Stewards

Humanity was not created because God lacked company. He already had that — a divine family, the *elohim*. Instead, humans were designed to be God's *image-bearers* on earth — physical representatives of His authority, mirroring the structure of His heavenly administration.

“Then God said, ‘Let us make man in our image, after our likeness. And let them have dominion over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the heavens and over the livestock and over all the earth and over every creeping thing that creeps on the earth.’”

— **Genesis 1:26-28**

As Dr. Michael Heiser explained:

“An image is a visible, physical representative that carries out the function of the one represented. In the ancient world, kings were often regarded as images of a god. In Genesis, all humanity is given that role.”

— **Unseen Realm, Ch. 14**

Parallel Households: Heavenly and Earthly

Just as God ruled over a divine council at the mountaintop, He intended to appoint humanity to govern His creation on earth.

Eden was more than a paradise — it was a **cosmic embassy**, where heaven and earth met. The human steward, Adam, was intended to serve as its priestly ambassador and earthly representative.

Winged Beings and Ancient Artifacts

Assyrian and Babylonian reliefs depict winged humanoids flanking sacred trees or kings. These figures often have bird-like wings and holding pouches — commonly interpreted as divine couriers delivering messages between the spirit and earthly realms.

The Epic of Gilgamesh

The Epic of Gilgamesh, with its quest for eternal life, is steeped in mountain imagery and guarded portals. Utnapishtim (the flood survivor) mirrors Genesis themes, including lost immortality. Scholars often note that this epic reveals mankind's early awareness of a once-accessible divine life source — much like the Tree of Life. In many ways, The Epic of Gilgamesh echoes the Edenic narrative.

These ancient secular images are not mentioned here to prove or disprove any biblical truth — but only to show that **the memory of**

divine guardianship, sacred space, and spiritual hierarchy was deeply embedded in ancient consciousness.

The biblical account is the original narrative. And the fact that other cultures remembered and reported on it, establishes its authenticity.

That pagan literature, such as The Epic of Gilgamesh, bears witness to humanity's ancient grief — its longing for a lost paradise with guarded access — is a desperate search for a pathway back to eternal life.

Anthropological Confirmation

Anthropologists have long noted that early human societies consistently associated the sacred with *elevation*. Whether in Babylon, Mesoamerica, or early Semitic cultures, high places and divine imagery are often found in tandem. Winged beings, radiant thrones, and mountain temples appear everywhere. They echoed patterns established initially by the one universal Creator God.

Scripture affirms the existence of spiritual beings before humanity. Some would later rebel — distorting the patterns God intended both in heaven and on earth. Whether that rebellion began before Eden or unfolded alongside humanity's story, the Bible is clear: divine order was challenged, both above and below.

The Rebellion Was Rooted in Envy

Before there were humans, there were *elohim* —members of God's heavenly family. To understand why the Tree of Life became inaccessible, we must first understand what provoked its guardians. The rupture wasn't only on the earth — it began in heaven...

The enemy's rage wasn't merely rebellion — it was resentment. It was jealousy over the favor God showed to humanity. Dominion had not

been given to the mighty ones of heaven, but to the fragile ones of earth. That decision enraged some among the divine council. Pride may have sparked their fall, but it was envy that fanned it into flame.

“Where were you when I laid the foundation of the earth? Tell me, if you understand. [5] Who determined its measurements — surely you know! Or who stretched the line upon it? [6] On what were its bases sunk, or who laid its cornerstone, [7] when the morning stars sang together and all the sons of God shouted for joy?”

— Job 38:4-7

These supernatural creatures were present when the foundations of the world were laid. They participated as part of God's Divine Council (**Psalm 82:1**).

But they were *not* made in God's image. They were spirit beings with assigned roles that were primarily in the heavens.

When God created humanity, He did something new. He formed us from the dust — yet crowned us with authority:

“Let us make man in our image, after our likeness. And let them have dominion...”

— Genesis 1:26

God created humans to **rule** — not above in “the heavens,” but **over the earth**. We are His physical image-bearers, governing the material world on His behalf.

“...what is man that you are mindful of him, and the son of man that you care for him? [5] Yet you have made him a little lower than the heavenly beings and crowned him with glory and honor. [6] You have given him dominion over the works of your hands; you have put all things under his feet...”

— Psalm 8:4-6

The heavens have a hierarchy. The *elohim* have power. But on the earth, imagers who were but “dust” were granted the dignity of dominion.

“When the Most High gave to the nations their inheritance, when He divided mankind, He fixed the borders of the peoples according to the number of the sons of God.”

— **Deuteronomy 32:8** (DSS and LXX)

When God disinherited the nations at Babel, He placed them under the oversight of angelic members of His divine council, known as the “sons of God.”

Christ’s inheritance will always remain: Israel.

*“But the Lord’s portion is His people,
Jacob his allotted heritage.”*

— **Deuteronomy 32:9**

NOTE: At the Tower of Babel, God *disinherited the nations* (**Deuteronomy 32:8-9**). He appointed members of His divine council — spiritual *elohim* — to govern the scattered *peoples, languages, and nations*.

So, God placed man under the governance of angelic administrators (Cf. **Daniel 10**, where the **Prince of Persia** and the **Prince of Greece** are mentioned).

Even so, still, some of those angelic governors ruled unjustly. They craved worship. They led nations astray. And that’s what we read in **Psalm 82...**

So God judged them:

“You are gods... but you shall die like men.”

— Psalm 82:6-7

And in their place, **God raised a human family** — one that would one day be glorified, resurrected, and seated with Christ...

[4] “But God, being rich in mercy, because of the great love with which He loved us, [5] even when we were dead in our trespasses, made us alive together with Christ...”

— Ephesians 2:4-5

And here is the punch line of all redemptive history:

*“It is not to angels that God has subjected
the world to come.”*

— Hebrews 2:5

*“The kingdom... shall be given
to the people of the saints of the Most High.”*

— Daniel 7:27

Some of those *elohim* “sons of God,” who had been tasked with ruling the nations justly, became corrupt. And Psalm 82 exposes their failure:

“I said, ‘You are gods, sons of the Most High, all of you; nevertheless, like men you shall die...”

— Psalm 82:6-7

Their rebellion was not just against order — it was against the **favor** God showed to humanity, and reminds us...

*“I will ascend... I will raise my throne...
I will make myself like the Most High.”*

— Isaiah 14:13-14

Lucifer the Lightbearer wanted to sit above the stars — to claim what God had given to Adam. His fury was hateful **jealousy**. To this very day, Lucifer can not stand that God's love and attention, and especially His image — had been given to these literal “dirtbags” of flesh.

The Father's Love

God knew what He was doing. He placed Adam and Eve in a world full of ancient beings — beings who had existed long before humans were created.

Adam wasn't naïve — he was **new**. And Eve was **vulnerable**. They were created in the image of God but had none of the experience of the elohim around them. And one of those beings — “the King of Tyre” — exploited their innocence.

“...more cunning than any beast of the field...”

— **Genesis 3:1**

“By the multitude of your iniquities, in the unrighteousness of your deceptions...”

— **Ezekiel 28:18**

(paraphrased)

The Tree of Life has a trajectory

[Eden → Paradise → New Jerusalem]

... it is the living thread woven through all of redemptive history.

This book follows that thread — from the mountain of beginnings, to the hidden waiting place of the righteous, to the city of glory where the nations will be healed.

Along the way, we will confront spiritual geography, angelic rebellion, divine justice, and the mystery of resurrection.

He clothed the man and the woman. But God judged the serpent.

And God promised:

“He shall crush your head...”

— **Genesis 3:15**

This was the beginning of a long redemption — one in which God's love would burn brighter than man's failure.

“As a father shows compassion to his children, so the Lord shows compassion to those who fear Him. For He knows our frame; He remembers that we are dust.”

— **Psalms 103:13-14**

The Tree of Life

The Tree of Life is not a tree. It is the visible sign of God's holy presence — His Shekhinah Glory. It was in the garden, in the center of the sacred grounds. Like the future burning bush, or the much more future tongues of fire of Pentecost, the Tree of Life was the Spirit of God making Himself known.

This book traces the Holy Spirit's sacred presence — from Eden's beginning to Paradise's waiting place, to the glory of the New Jerusalem — where the nations will once again dwell in the Shekhinah Glory of God.

We first encounter it in Eden — the original mountain of God, where heaven touched earth and man walked with his Creator. But access was lost. Not because God is cruel, but because life cannot dwell with rebellion. A cherub with a flaming sword was stationed to guard it —

not out of wrath, but mercy. For if man had taken from it in his fallen state, he would have sealed his doom.

Jesus told the thief on the cross, “Today you will be with Me in Paradise.” Paul speaks of being caught up to Paradise. Revelation says the Tree of Life is in Paradise — and later, in the New Jerusalem. The righteous dead were not abandoned to silence. They were comforted. Sustained. Awaiting resurrection beneath the Tree they once lost.

This is a book of reality.

Eden was not just the location of God’s presence — it was the launching point of humanity’s purpose. Created in the image of God and placed “in the midst” of the garden, mankind was intended to steward sacred space, dwell in fellowship, and walk in divine proximity. But something went wrong. A rival voice twisted the truth. A fracture began at the summit — not just in geography, but in allegiance.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. The chapter describes Eden not just as a garden, but as a **mountain** — a meeting place of the divine and earthly realms. How does this understanding of Eden as a mountain change or expand your view of the creation narrative?
2. The text highlights the common thread of mountain imagery across many ancient cultures. Why do you think this pattern exists in human memory and literature, even outside of the biblical narrative?
3. Eden was seen as a **cosmic embassy** — a place of God's dwelling and human stewardship. What does this role of humanity as "image-bearers" and **ambassadors** reveal about our spiritual purpose today?
4. The chapter mentions that some angelic beings grew envious of humanity's intended dominion over the earth. What does this reveal about the spiritual dynamics behind Eden's fall, and how might it inform our understanding of spiritual warfare in the present?
5. Discuss the implications of Eden's vertical structure (summit to garden) for our relationship with God. What does this structure teach us about the nature of divine fellowship and our intended place in creation?

“THE FALL”



THE FALL, THE GUARDIAN, AND THE FLAMING SWORD

EXILE FROM THE SUMMIT AND THE SHIFTING GEOGRAPHY OF GLORY

God's Command of Warning: The Test in the Garden

[15] "The LORD God took the man and put him in the garden of Eden to work it and keep it. [16] And the LORD God commanded the man, saying, You may surely eat of every tree of the garden, [17] but of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil you shall not eat, for in the day that you eat of it you shall surely die."— **Genesis 2:15-17**

God placed Adam into a holy sanctuary — the garden. The Tree of Life was there. And so was the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. God gave Adam (and Eve) a divine assignment: Eat of *any* tree, but not of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. Don't even touch it!

It was a test of loyalty, obedience — and survival. God needed to know if Adam and Eve could be trusted.

The Voice of the Serpent — Temptation and Deception

[1] "Now the serpent was more crafty than any other beast of the field that the LORD God had made. He said to the woman, "Did God actually say,

‘You shall not eat of any tree in the garden?’ ...[6] So when the woman saw that the tree was good for food, and that it was a delight to the eyes, and that the tree was to be desired to make one wise, she took its fruit and ate, and she also gave some to her husband who was with her, and he ate.”

— **Genesis 3:1-6**

And this is where all of humanity’s problems began: WITH A DECEPTIVE LIE.

Lucifer's Ascent and Fall

The Backstory: Once upon a time, there was the most beautiful angel among all that God had created. His name was Lucifer, the Light-bearer. With all the attributes God had blessed him with, Lucifer’s beauty went to his head — he became pompous, corrupt, and down-right evil. Lies and deception became his trademark.

In Ezekiel 28 and Isaiah 14, we see the future — what is yet to be the serpent’s recompense. In these two passages the inhabitants of Hades will be mocking in unison the newest exile from the earth’s surface...

[13] “You were in Eden, the garden of God; every precious stone was your covering...and crafted in gold were your settings and your engravings... [14] You were an anointed guardian cherub. ...you were on the holy mountain of God; in the midst of the stones of fire, you walked. [15] You were blameless in your ways from the day you were created till unrighteousness was found in you. [17] Your heart was proud because of your beauty; you corrupted your wisdom for the sake of your splendor. (God) exposed you before kings, to feast their eyes on you.”

— **Ezekiel 28:13-17**

[9] “Sheol beneath is stirred up to meet you when you come; it rouses the shades to greet you, all who were leaders of the earth; it raises from their thrones all who were kings of the nations. [10] All of them will answer and say to you: ‘You too have become as weak as we! You have become like us!’

[11] Your pomp is brought down to Sheol, the sound of your harps; maggots are laid as a bed beneath you, and worms are your covers.”

— **Isaiah 14:9-11**

The Guardian and the Flaming Sword

[22] “Then the LORD God said, ‘Behold, the man has become like one of us in knowing good and evil. Now, lest he reach out his hand and take also of the tree of life and eat, and live forever —’ [23] therefore the LORD God sent him out from the garden of Eden to work the ground from which he was taken.”

— **Genesis 3:22-23**

Mercy at the Edge of Eden

When Adam and Eve sinned, the Tree of Life remained in the garden, in the place God had planted it—still in the midst, still radiant, still a source of divine sustenance. But access to it was now dangerous.

“Then the Lord God said, ‘Behold, the man has become like one of us in knowing good and evil. Now, lest he reach out his hand and take also of the Tree of Life and eat, and live forever—”

— **Genesis 3:22**

NOTE: Some translations mistakenly capitalize “Us” in *Genesis 3:22* — thereby implying the Trinity. That demonstrates a failure to comprehend the ancient context.

As noted by Dr. Michael Heiser (The Unseen Realm), the plural pronoun “us” refers not to the Triune God conversing with Himself, but instead to God speaking with His divine council. God is ONE, and He is *not* schizophrenic.

The Divine Council (see Psalm 82) is a spiritual assembly of lesser *elohim* who serve under Elohim’s supreme authority. This gives us a rich glimpse into God’s heavenly court.

The God of Israel is *One*, yet He invites participation from His

created heavenly beings. This peek into the heavenly court clarifies why God's next move was so critical.

God interrupted Himself.

God never finished His sentence in Genesis 3:22. Why? Because He realized the horror of the moment. Humanity had “fallen” — severed itself from holiness, fellowship, and life.

The serpent's psyop had enticed Eve, and she, having free will, had disobeyed God's specific command. And Adam did, also.

*“Now may the God of peace Himself sanctify you completely, and may your **whole spirit and soul and body** be kept blameless at the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ.”*

— **1 Thessalonians 5:23**

NOTE: God created humans with three components: spirit, soul, and body.

At some point, the supernatural parts entered them. Perhaps it was when God breathed the breath of life into them.

The soul that “links” us to God. People often get this wrong and say it's the spirit, but it's the soul. The spirit is our eternal identity. The Fall was the first incident where “the stain” of sin damaged human souls and interfered with the relationship between God and man.

“Then the Lord God formed the man of dust from the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life, and the man became a living being.”

— **Genesis 2:7**

NOTE: Re: Genesis 2:7, the KJV says, “*and man became a living soul.*” [Biblehub.com/Strong's 5315](https://www.biblehub.com/Strong's/5315) - *nephesh* meaning “soul,” “life,” “self,” “person,” “creature,” “living being.” The key point to be made is that sin causes a degree of separation from God. Disobedience to God is a

serious offense that warrants a consequence, i.e., some form of punishment.

On the other hand, continued access to the eternal life that would result from eating the fruit of the Tree of Life risked innumerable generations of sinful humanity. Step 1: Isolate them from the Tree of Life. Step 2: Demand a consequence. Step 3: Provide a compassionate pathway to redemption.

The Protective Ban

“He drove out the man, and to the east of the garden of Eden, He placed the cherubim and a flaming sword that turned every way to guard the way to the Tree of Life.”

— **Genesis 3:24**

That was a temporary fix. God **protected** His beloved new family from a horrific fate. Their once glorious bodies would wear out, die, and decay due to the rigors of hard labor, sickness, and wars — the punishment. But what to do about their soul and their spirit? For those, God needed an eternal fix — and He had *The Perfect Solution*.

Divine Compassion

Had Adam and Eve remained in the garden and eventually eaten the fruit of the Tree of Life — and become immortal, God would have had no choice but to strike them down. His plan, however, gave them time — and the space — for redemption.

This is **divine compassion**. A mercy that punishes, yet preserves. A justice that closes one door, only to open another.

“Cursed is the ground because of you... By the sweat of your brow you shall eat bread... till you return to the ground, for out of it you were taken.”

— **Genesis 3:17-19 paraphrased**

Life, from that point forward, would be complicated by:

Labor. Pain. And Death.

Yet even in judgment... mercy remained.

God never stopped loving them — even then. He clothed them. He spoke to them. He remained near.

“He shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise His heel.”

— **Genesis 3:15**

The Messiah would come. The serpent would be crushed.

The Tree in Paradise

When Jesus hung on the cross between two criminals, one mocked — but the other believed.

“Jesus, remember me when You come into Your kingdom.” And He said to him, “Truly, I say to you, today you will be with Me in Paradise.”

— **Luke 23:42-43**

Jesus did not say, “Someday, far in the future, you’ll be with Me in heaven.” He said **today**—and He said **Paradise**. That word, *paradeisos*, is the Greek equivalent of the Hebrew *gan* — meaning “garden.”

Paradise is not to be confused with Heaven, as we often imagine it. Nevertheless, Paradise is a place of **peace, rest, and God’s presence**.

“To the one who conquers I will grant to eat of the Tree of Life, which is in the Paradise of God.”

— **Revelation 2:7**

Paradise (comfort for the righteous) is the antithesis of Hades (tor-

ment for the unrighteous) — and both are compartments within Sheol — the ancient unseen realm where the dead await the resurrection.

Thus ends this chapter. Yet the story of the Tree of Life and God's redemptive plan continues. Paradise is not lost. For those judged righteous, the Spirit of God and His Tree of Life are there—waiting to comfort and sustain us until the resurrection.



Reflect & Discuss

1. What does the command God gave to Adam (Genesis 2:15-17) reveal about His desire for human obedience and trust? How does this compare to other biblical commands or covenants?
2. The serpent's question ("Did God actually say...?") represents a direct challenge to God's authority and truth. How does this ancient lie echo in today's world, and what are some modern "serpent lies" we face?
3. The text notes that after the fall, God's response was both judgment and mercy. What does this dual action teach us about the nature of God's justice and compassion?
4. The chapter discusses the concept of the Divine Council and God's heavenly court. How does this help expand your understanding of the plural "us" in Genesis 3:22?
5. Reflect on the final promise in Genesis 3:15 — "He shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise His heel." How does this early prophecy shape your view of God's redemptive plan and the ultimate defeat of evil?

THE SACRED GEOGRAPHY OF EDEN

FROM SUMMIT TO SOIL: AND THE TREE THAT SPANNED THE DIVIDE.

This is what the Bible says:

Eden → Sheol's Paradise → New Jerusalem

“And out of the ground the LORD God made to spring up every tree that is pleasant to the sight and good for food. The Tree of Life was in the midst of the garden...”

— Genesis 2:9

The Mountain and the Garden: The Sacred Structure of Eden

In the biblical cosmology, *the Mountain of God* and *the Garden of Eden* are related but distinct zones within sacred geography:

The **Mountain of God** refers to the cosmic high place — the spiritual pinnacle where heaven and earth intersect. It is the throne zone, cloaked in glory and “clouds,” a recurring symbol of divine habitation (Cf. Exodus 24:15-18, Psalm 48:1-2, Ezekiel 28:13-14).

The **Garden of Eden** lies at the **base** of this mountain — nourished by springs and rivers that flow *down* from above (**Genesis 2:10-14**). The garden is lush, abundant, and filled with sacred trees — including the Tree of Life — where God meets with His human creation.

God's throne was at the summit, while His **Spirit** was present **in the garden**. Whether there was any descent by divine pathway is irrelevant. What matters is that **the Tree of Life** stood *in the midst* of the garden as the locus of fellowship and sustenance.

The Mount and Eden were a **vertical construct**, with a divine presence spanning from the summit to the soil. In this view, God did not need to “walk down the mountain” in a human-like sense. Instead, His Spirit radiated from the Tree of Life, which stood in the midst of the garden — the meeting point of Creator and creature.

God's Divine Descent Moments in Scripture

- **Genesis 11:5** — “*And the LORD came down to see the city...*”
- **Exodus 19:20** — “*The LORD came down to Mount Sinai...*”
- **Genesis 18:1** — “*The LORD appeared to Abraham by the oaks of Mamre...*”

The Tree of Life as Theophany — God Present in the Midst

- **Exodus 3** — The burning bush: fire in a tree but not consuming it.
- **Exodus 25:22** — God says, “There I will meet with you... from above the mercy seat.”
- **Acts 2** — The Spirit descends as tongues of fire, resting on each believer.

"In the Cool of the Day" — Ruach in Motion

The phrase “*cool of the day*” can also be rendered “*in the breeze of the day*” — using the Hebrew word רֵיחַ (*ruach*), which also means **Spirit** or **wind**. This hints at the **movement of God’s Spirit**, stirring creation and signaling His approach.

In Judaism, the Holy Spirit (Hebrew: *Ruach HaKodesh*) is conceived of *as the divine force, quality, and influence of God over the universe or God’s creatures, in specific contexts*.

It wasn't just footsteps. It was **presence** — Spirit stirring the garden, drawing near.

The point is this: Before the fall, there was no barrier between the heights and the garden below. The Mountain of God was accessible.

Whether God descended along a sacred pathway or manifested in the Tree itself, His presence was tangible. He *walked* with His creation.

The garden was not merely a paradise — it was a place of communion. This is the Edenic cosmogram — a vertical meeting point between heaven and earth, crowned with intimacy and shattered by sin.

How God arrived in the garden from the place of the divine council behind the clouds that covered the pinnacle of the Mountain of God is neither here nor there. What’s important is that He *did*.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. In the biblical account, how are the *Mountain of God* and the *Garden of Eden* described as distinct yet interconnected realms? Why is this important in understanding sacred geography?
2. How does the concept of the *Tree of Life in the midst of the garden* reflect God's presence and communion with His creation?
3. The chapter mentions that there was no barrier between the heights of the mountain and the garden below before the fall. What does this teach us about God's original intent for creation?
4. How does the vertical construct of "summit to soil" — with God's throne at the top and His Spirit in the garden — help us understand the Edenic pattern of divine presence?
5. Reflect on the idea of God's Spirit *moving in the breeze of the day* (ruach). How does this imagery deepen our appreciation of God's relational presence with humanity in the garden?

WHERE IS SHEOL?

THE SUBTERRANEAN GEOGRAPHY OF THE AFTERLIFE

Before the resurrection, there will be Sheol — the destination of *all* the dead. From the soil our bodies came, and to the soil they return. But our disembodied soul and spirit have a layover in Sheol.

When we die, we are immediately judged — even before we're buried:

“...it is appointed for man to die once, and after that comes judgment,”
— **Hebrews 9:27**

The Bible states that angels are “ministering spirits” (Hebrews 1:14), which some interpret as including roles in death or the transition to the afterlife. The most explicit biblical mention of angels escorting a soul or spirit to Sheol's Paradise occurs in the story of Abraham's Bosom:

“The poor man died and was carried by the angels to Abraham's side.”
— **Luke 16:22**

Throughout history, people have described seeing an angel or a

shadowy figure near the doorway during their final hours. If judged righteous, they are guided to Paradise; if judged unrighteous, to Hades. Either way, Sheol is their destination.

When Jesus was crucified, He spoke a promise to the repentant thief:

“Today you will be with Me in paradise.”

— **Luke 23:43**

NOTE: Jesus did not say, “Today you will be with Me in heaven.” He said “*in paradise*” — (*Gr. paradeiso*), the same word used for the righteous side of Sheol. Immediately after Jesus died, His spirit descended to Sheol’s Paradise. Strong’s Greek 3857 *Parádeisos* is the righteous side of Sheol. (cf. 2 Corinthians 12:4 and Revelation 2:7)

Three days later, Jesus resurrected to the surface of the earth:

“In saying, ‘He ascended,’ what does it mean but that He had also descended to the lower regions, the earth?”

— **Ephesians 4:9**

In Second Temple Jewish literature (like 1 Enoch), angels are often depicted as escorts or watchers over souls in the afterlife. Then, forty days after Jesus was resurrected from Paradise back to the surface, He ascended from the surface to God’s heavenly abode. But even before that, Jesus told His disciples...

“Little children, yet a little while I am with you. You will seek me, and just as I said to the Jews, so now I also say to you, ‘Where I am going you cannot come.’”

— **John 13:33** (Jesus)

“You are from below; I am from above. You are of this world; I am not of this world.”

— **John 8:23**

*“No one has ascended into heaven except He who descended from heaven,
the Son of Man.”*

— **John 3:13** (Jesus)

Conclusion

No human has ever died and gone “*up to Heaven*” except Jesus, Son of Man. All humans, righteous or unrighteous, go *down* to Sheol—the righteous to Paradise; the unrighteous to Hades.

To those who believe the righteous die and go “*up to Heaven*,” let me be clear: Paradise is a place of comfort and rest, as many of us think Heaven to be. If you are righteous and deserving of “Heaven,” you won’t be disappointed finding yourself in Paradise. It’s only a matter of direction: up or down. The correct biblical answer is: *Down*.

The familiar phrase from Paul’s letter also holds:

*“...we are of good courage, and we would rather be away from the body and
at home with the Lord.”*

— **2 Corinthians 5:8**

Since God is omnipresent — that cliché is indisputable!

In closing this introductory summation, let me assure you: If your name is in the Lamb’s book of life — if you bear the mark of God on your forehead, the Tree of Life (God’s Holy Spirit) is standing by in Paradise to welcome you. You can’t miss Him — look for the Tree illuminated by His Shekhinah Glory!

Having established Sheol as the first destination after death, let us now journey deeper — into the nature of Sheol itself and the mysteries that await there.

The Soul and Spirit in Sheol

Scripture distinguishes between soul and spirit. Hebrews 4:12 and 1 Thessalonians 5:23 confirm that humans are composed of body, soul, and spirit. The soul is often the seat of our spiritual longing and connection to God — “*My soul thirsts for God, for the living God*” (Psalm 42:2). The spirit, by contrast, carries our identity, our awareness and memory — the breath of God that returns to Him at death (Ecclesiastes 12:7).

In Sheol, this distinction takes on new significance. Scripture suggests that the soul’s purpose is to connect us with God. When cut off from Him, the soul’s vital function is lost.

The righteous dead in Paradise — “*souls under the altar*” (Revelation 6:9) — remain spiritually alive, still praising God. But the spirits of the wicked in Hades, cut off from this vital bond, have no ongoing soul function. Their separation from God is complete.

In brief, the soul serves as the link to God. The spirit carries the “self.” In Sheol’s Paradise, the souls of the righteous reach for the light of the Tree of Life — a living testimony that death does not have the final word.

Witness of the Ancients

Ancient Jewish and early Christian sources enrich this picture.

- The **Book of Enoch** (1 Enoch 22) describes Sheol as a mountain with separate compartments, one for the righteous and another for the wicked, with peace and torment, respectively.
- The **Early Church Fathers**, including Irenaeus and Tertullian, affirmed that the righteous dead find repose in Paradise — a temporary comfort until the resurrection.

The wicked remain in Hades, cut off from God's life-giving presence.

Thus, Sheol is not the final fate, but a temporary holding ground — a place of waiting and anticipation.

The Biblical Witness: Sheol is Real — and It is Temporary

The righteous and the wicked alike go to Sheol. Even Jesus entered Sheol's Paradise after His death...

“For just as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the great fish, so will the Son of Man be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth.”

— **Matthew 12:40**

[42] *“And he said, ‘Jesus, remember me when you come into your kingdom.’*

[43] *And He said to him, ‘Truly, I say to you, today you will be with me in paradise.’”*

— **Luke 23:42-43**

David, Job, and the prophets spoke of this realm—a layered domain beneath the earth, described in verses such as...

“For a fire is kindled by my anger, and it burns to the depths of Sheol, devours the earth and its increase, and sets on fire the foundations of the mountains.”

— **Deuteronomy 32:22**

In **Luke 16:19-31**, Jesus reveals the stark divide within Sheol:

- **Paradise (Abraham's Bosom)** — a place of peace and comfort.
- **Hades** — a place of torment, regret, and separation.
- A great, fixed **chasm** (Luke 16:26).

In this divine geography, the righteous find comfort, while the wicked are in agony. I'm presenting Jesus' story (not a parable) of the Rich Man and Lazarus in its entirety because I believe it's essential that you read it in its full context.

The Rich Man and Lazarus

16 [19] *"There was a rich man who was clothed in purple and fine linen and who feasted sumptuously every day. [20] And at his gate was laid a poor man named Lazarus, covered with sores, [21] who desired to be fed with what fell from the rich man's table. Moreover, even the dogs came and licked his sores. [22] The poor man died and was carried by the angels to Abraham's side. The rich man also died and was buried, [23] and in Hades, being in torment, he lifted up his eyes and saw Abraham far off and Lazarus at his side. [24] And he called out, 'Father Abraham, have mercy on me, and send Lazarus to dip the end of his finger in water and cool my tongue, for I am in anguish in this flame.' [25] But Abraham said, 'Child, remember that you in your lifetime received your good things, and Lazarus in like manner bad things; but now he is comforted here, and you are in anguish. [26] And besides all this, between us and you a great chasm has been fixed, so that those who would pass from here to you may not be able, and none may cross from there to us.' [27] And he said, 'Then I beg you, father, to send him to my father's house—[28] for I have five brothers—so that he may warn them, lest they also come into this place of torment.' [29] But Abraham said, 'They have Moses and the Prophets; let them hear them.' [30] And he said, 'No, father Abraham, but if someone goes to them from the dead, they will repent.' [31] He said to him, 'If they do not hear Moses and the Prophets, neither will they be convinced if someone should rise from the dead.'"*

— Luke 16:19-31

A Place of Awareness and Anticipation

The disembodied spirits remember, recognize, and experience

comfort or torment. Sheol is a realm of anticipation — a cosmic pause awaiting the resurrection.

Christ Descended into Sheol's Paradise

After His death on the Cross, Christ descended to Sheol — to the Paradise side. You may have been falsely taught that Jesus descended into hell. But that is *not* what the Bible teaches. His presence in Paradise was not to suffer further in “hell,” or to preach a message of redemption to the irredeemable spirits of Hades. But to assure the righteous of the certainty of the resurrection and the fulfillment of God's covenants.

The Purpose of Christ's Descent

When Jesus died, He did not immediately ascend to Heaven. Instead, He descended to Sheol's Paradise — into the “heart of the earth” — **to proclaim His victory over death and confirm the hope of resurrection to the righteous dead.**

Paradise Was Never the Final Destination

The descent of Christ was not to empty Sheol — not yet. That day, the Day of the Lord, is still ahead. Jesus descended into Paradise **to fulfill prophecy and to proclaim victory over death.**

The First Resurrection — The Vindication of the Righteous

“They came to life and reigned with Christ for a thousand years.”

— Revelation 20:4

Christ was the first half of the First Resurrection — the first of the Firstfruits. That's why it says, *“He led them.”* He was the first. The rest will follow at the appointed time.

The Day of the Lord: The Final Gathering

On that Day, when Christ returns to the earth in glory, *all* the righteous dead in Paradise will be raised to the surface in glorified, immortal bodies. They will be joined by the living righteous, who will be “changed,” and together they will rise to meet Christ in the air — not to continue to God’s heavenly abode, but to make a U-turn and return to the earth with Him, just as the crowds did on the first Palm Sunday. This is captured by the Greek words: ἀπάντησις (*apántēsis* – to meet), ἐπισυναγωγή (*episynagógē* – to gather together), and ἐπανέρχομαι (*epanérchomai* or *parousia*– to return).

The Blessed Hope

This is what all the righteous of all time are waiting for — it is *our blessed hope...*

“...waiting for our blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ,...”

— Titus 2:13

This is not a rapture to Heaven. That never happens! It is the fulfillment of all that Paradise holds in trust for us — the resurrection and reunion of the righteous to share in Christ’s millennial reign. In all this, the Spirit of God has never been absent — He has always dwelt with the righteous and will continue to do so forever.

“Where shall I go from your Spirit? Or where shall I flee from your presence? If I ascend to heaven, you are there! If I make my bed in Sheol, you are there!”

— Psalm 139:7-8

Common Misunderstanding: “Heaven is the Final Home of the Righteous”

Many sincere believers imagine that the ultimate goal of faith is to “go to heaven and live with God forever.” But here’s what Jesus teaches us in the Bible...

Nobody Goes to Heaven — Everybody Goes to Sheol

While Scripture promises believers immediate spiritual fellowship with Christ at death (Philippians 1:23; 2 Corinthians 5:8), the Bible’s ultimate hope is not merely a disembodied existence in the heavenly realms.

Instead, it is the **resurrection of the dead** and the **renewal of the earth** — God’s original design.

The Bible declares:

- **Resurrection of the Body:** “The dead in Christ will rise” (1 Thessalonians 4:16).
- **Restoration - Make Like Eden Again - Christ’s Millennial Reign:** “Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth” (Revelation 21:1).
- **God Dwelling with Us on Earth:** “Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man” (Revelation 21:3).

The ultimate destiny of the righteous is **not to leave creation behind** — but to inherit it in glory, alongside Christ, as part of God’s redeemed kingdom.

[15] “For we declare to you by a word from the Lord, that we who are alive, who are left until the coming of the Lord, will not precede those who have fallen asleep. [16] Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a cry of command, with the voice of an archangel, and with the sound of the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first. [17] Then we who are alive, who are left, will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air, and so we will always be with the Lord.”

— 1 Thessalonians 4:15-17

[1] “Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth, for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away, and the sea was no more. [2] And I saw the holy city, New Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride adorned for her husband.

— Revelation 21:1-2

“And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying, ‘Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be His people, and God Himself will be with them as their God.’”

— Revelation 21:3

Sheol's Paradise is not the final destination. It is the place of waiting for the First Resurrection. Christ the firstfruit. Then the rest of the righteous dead — on the appointed day. Sheol is the realm of anticipation — awaiting something cosmic. Something climactic. It is awaiting **the resurrection!**

Christ's Descent into Sheol

The cross was not the end of Jesus' mission — it was the turning point.

When Jesus breathed His last, He did not ascend immediately to Heaven. According to His own words — and affirmed by the apostles — He descended into Sheol's Paradise, **into the heart of the earth.**

“For just as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the great fish, so will the Son of Man be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth.”

— Matthew 12:40

The Purpose of His Descent

Jesus did not descend to Sheol to suffer more. On the cross, He declared: “It is finished.” And what’s more: He did not descend to preach salvation to the demon spirits!

Who Are the “Spirits in Prison” in 1 Peter 3:19?

[19] “For Christ also suffered once for sins, the righteous for the unrighteousness, that He might bring us to God, being put to death in the flesh but made alive in the spirit, in which He went and proclaimed to the spirits in prison, [20] because they formerly did not obey, when God’s patience waited in the days of Noah, while the ark was being prepared...”

— 1 Peter 3:19-20

Christ descended to Sheol — to the Paradise side! He did *not* “descend to hell” — that would be absurd! And what’s more is that Christ *did not preach* a message of salvation to the disembodied demon spirits in Hades — demon spirits are irredeemable. If Jesus said anything to the demon spirits — it was **a taunt!**

So, if not those eternally damned in Hades, who do you suspect *was* His audience? And what *was* His message?

Biblehub.com/Strong's 2784 - Gr. *kerysso* means Jesus was “a herald sent by God” to encourage the righteous spirits with His proclamation: **“Total Victory!”**

Jesus descended to Sheol’s Paradise and joined all the other righteous dead. Abraham and Lazarus were there, and David, Job, Joseph, Isaiah, Noah — and all the righteous ancient patriarchs — as well as those who had just arrived just moments before. The second part of Jesus’ message? ***“Your resurrection is certain!”***

The Great Confirmation

The righteous believed — but they had never seen. Now, Jesus the Promised One, stood before them bearing the marks of His death.

“You will not let your Holy One see corruption.”

— Psalm 16:10

While Jesus’ body remained in the tomb, His spirit was alive, conscious, moving, and talking — below — in Sheol’s Paradise.

Not One Accompanied Him Out

Despite centuries of Christian art and legend depicting Jesus “emptying Hades,” Scripture presents a more precise sequence: Paradise was visited, but not vacated. Not yet. That will come later...at the end of the age. Today, the martyrs and all the righteous dead still wait.

6 [9] *“When He opened the fifth seal, I saw under the altar the souls of those who had been slain for the word of God and for the witness they had borne. [10] They cried out with a loud voice, ‘O Sovereign LORD, holy and true, how long before you will judge and avenge our blood on those who dwell on the earth?’ [11] Then they were each given a white robe and told to rest a little longer, until the number of their fellow servants and their brothers should be complete, who were to be killed, as they had been.”*

— Revelation 6:9-11

(The 5th Seal)

7 [9] *“After this I looked, and behold, a great multitude that no one could number, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages, standing before the throne and before the Lamb, clothed in white robes, with palm branches in their hands, [10] and crying out with a loud voice, ‘Salvation belongs to our God who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb!’*

— Revelation 7:9-10

The presence of an altar in this vision suggests that it is located in Sheol's Paradise. Furthermore, the white robes given to the martyrs might be their new, glorified, and immortal bodies — prepared in Paradise before the resurrection of the righteous.

*“To the one who conquers I will grant to eat of the Tree of Life, **which is in the Paradise of God.**”*

— Revelation 2:7

110 [3] *“Your people will offer themselves freely on the day of your power, in holy garments; from the womb of the morning, the dew of your youth will be yours. [4] The LORD has sworn and will not change His mind, ‘You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek.*

— Psalm 110:3-4

NOTE: re: Revelation 2:7: Present tense: *Not was in; not will be in*; the Tree of Life “**is in.**” The Tree of Life is currently *still* in Paradise.

Paradise Was Never the Final Destination

The descent of Christ was *not to empty Sheol* — not yet. That day — the day of the Lord — is still ahead. Jesus descended into Paradise to fulfill prophecy and to proclaim victory over death.

The First Resurrection — The Vindication of the Righteous

“They came to life and reigned with Christ for a thousand years.”

— Revelation 20:4

Jesus was the first half of the First Resurrection — the first of the Firstfruits. That's why it says, “**He led them.**” He was the first. The rest will follow at the appointed time.

When might that be? On the day of the Lord when Christ returns to the earth — His Second (and final) Coming. On that day and at that

time, *all* the righteous dead in Paradise will be raised to the surface of the earth in unison — in glorified, immortal bodies. This is the second half of the First Resurrection. They will be joined by the righteous alive, who will be “changed,” and together they will rise and meet Christ in the air. Not to fly off to God’s heavenly abode, but to be gathered to Him, and return to the earth with Him to launch His millennial reign.

“Blessed and holy is the one who shares in the first resurrection! Over such, the second death has no power, but they will be priests of God and of Christ, and they will reign with Him for a thousand years.”

— **Revelation 20:6**

This is what all the righteous of all time are waiting for — it is **“our blessed hope”**...

2 [13] *“...our blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ, [14] who gave Himself for us to redeem us...”*

— **Titus 2:13-14**

The following verse is a clear, direct statement of the grand purpose — God’s intention to restore *all things* spoken by the prophets, seamlessly linking to our theme of Edenic renewal...

“...whom heaven must receive until the time for restoring all the things about which God spoke by the mouth of his holy prophets long ago.”

— **Acts 3:21**

This highlights creation’s eager anticipation for restoration through the glorified saints...

“For the creation waits with eager longing for the revealing of the sons of God. For the creation was subjected to futility, not willingly, but because of him who subjected it, in hope that the creation itself will be set free from its

bondage to corruption and obtain the freedom of the glory of the children of God.”

— **Romans 8:19–21**

Isaiah’s vision of total renewal anticipates the earth’s Edenic restoration...

“For behold, I create new heavens and a new earth, and the former things shall not be remembered or come into mind.”

— **Isaiah 65:17**

Conclusion

While the world will tremble under the judgments of the Day of the Lord, the righteous — clothed in immortal, imperishable bodies — will be immune to its horrors. We will not be swept away by the Seven Bowls of God’s orgé wrath.

Instead, as Revelation 21 and Isaiah 65 declare, we will join Christ in restoring the earth itself—bringing creation back to its Edenic harmony so that the Father can deliver the New Jerusalem without losing a minute.”

NOTE: Satan’s great tribulation (Strong’s Greek 2347, *thlipsis*) will be temporary persecution. Christ will pour out God’s wrath (Strong’s Greek 3709, *orgé*) on the Day of the Lord.

That topic will be discussed in detail in one of The Restoration Series: *The Day of the Lord* volumes.



Reflect & Discuss

1. How does understanding Sheol as a real and temporary abode for the dead (with Paradise and Hades as its chambers) shape your view of the afterlife? — *Scripture references: Luke 16:19–31; Psalm 16:10.*
2. What difference does it make to see Sheol not as final judgment, but as an interim realm of waiting for the resurrection? — *How might this bring comfort or hope in times of grief?*
3. Why do you think modern readers often conflate Sheol with Hell? — *How does this chapter help clarify that misunderstanding?*
4. Jesus said, “No one has ascended into heaven except He who descended from heaven” (John 3:13). How does this statement challenge popular beliefs about the destination of souls?
5. What did you find most surprising about Sheol’s role in the biblical worldview — and how does it change your perspective on life, death, and resurrection?

7 CORE TRUTHS REVEALED IN LUKE 16:19-31

Jesus was revealing — not just telling a parable. Luke 16 is a **theological x-ray** of the afterlife before the resurrection. Here are the **unmistakable truths** it unveils:

1. Sheol Has Two Compartments

- One of comfort (**Paradise / Abraham's bosom / Comfort**)
- One of torment (**Hades / Anguish**)

These are co-located but divided — not Heaven and Hell, but pre-resurrection holding zones.

2. Both Compartments Are Occupied

- The dead are conscious, aware, and responsive.
- They see, speak, remember, suffer, and reason.

This refutes the idea of “soul sleep” and affirms a living state of waiting.

3. Paradise Is Not in Heaven

- Abraham is not in God's heavenly abode (**John 3:13; 13:33**).
- Lazarus is with him, beneath the earth's surface.

Paradise is Sheol's comfort side — not Heaven's upper court.

4. Torment in Hades Is Real

- The flame is spiritual, but the agony is absolute.
- The rich man experiences real thirst and anguish.

This is not yet the final judgment of the Lake of Fire.

5. A Great Chasm Is Fixed

- There is no crossing between the two realms.
- Post-mortem repentance or judgment reversal is impossible.

The verdict at death is sealed.

6. The Word of God Is the Final Authority

- Abraham affirms Scripture as the dividing line:

“If they do not listen to Moses and the Prophets, they will not be convinced even if someone rises from the dead.”

7. Jesus Is Foreshadowing Our Resurrection

- He knows what is coming.
- He knows the righteous will rise to live again.



WHERE DID JESUS GO WHEN HE DIED?

Where Was Jesus Between His Death and His Resurrection?

Jesus was entirely man and fully God. First, we will consider His human nature.

“He was put to death in the body but made alive in the Spirit.”

— **1 Peter 3:18b**

Jesus' body was in the tomb from the time it was placed there until His resurrection, which we celebrate on Easter Sunday.

But from the moment of His death upon the Cross until His resurrection, His Spirit was in Sheol's Paradise.

“And He said to him, ‘Truly, I say to you, today you will be with me in paradise.’”

— **Luke 23:43**

Join us in Chapter 6, and I'll tell you all about it...





JESUS DESCENDED INTO PARADISE

WHAT HAPPENED BETWEEN THE CROSS AND THE RESURRECTION

He did not ascend before He first descended.

Do you believe the Bible? Here's what it says: Humans never go to the celestial heaven, the abode of God. Jesus Himself declared this:

*"No one has ever gone into heaven except the one who came from heaven —
the Son of Man."
— John 3:13*

Humans are earthbound. We live, die, and visit Sheol in the inner earth — the realm of the dead. Ultimately, we will be resurrected back to the surface of the planet. Jesus said,

*"...You are from below; I am from above. You are of this world; I am not of
this world."
— John 8:23*

Speaking of the resurrection of the dead, Jesus said,

“Do not be amazed at this, for a time is coming when all who are in their graves will hear his voice and come out — those who have done what is good will rise to live.”

— **John 5:28**

And again, Jesus said of the righteous dead:

“...but I will raise them up at the last day.”

— **John 6:39c**

“...and I will raise them up at the last day.”

— **John 6:44b**

Conclusion

No human ever goes *up* to the celestial heaven; only the Son of Man did when He ascended. Man's abode is planet Earth. Wherever it is that the soul-spirit of man goes for the afterlife, it is *down*, not *up*. Elijah was an anthropomorphic elohim on special assignment from God. (Read all about Elijah in my upcoming book, “Erroneous Assumptions in Modern Christianity.”)

When Daniel died, he did not go to celestial heaven; he went somewhere else:

“As for you, go your way till the end. You will rest, and then at the end of the days you will rise to receive your allotted inheritance.”

— **Daniel 12:13**

Why is it that we rarely hear teachings about what happened between the Cross and Jesus' resurrection? That'll be my mission for today.

What happened to Daniel when he died?

Wherever it was that Daniel's soul-spirit went, it was down — because on the day of the Lord, when Christ returns, Daniel's soul-spirit “will rise!”

What happened to David when he died?

When David died, his body was buried. His soul-spirit did *not* go up to “heaven”; he went somewhere else.

“For David did not ascend to heaven.”

— Acts 2:34

If even righteous Biblical personalities such as Daniel and David did not die and ascend to celestial heaven — where are they?

Conclusion #1:

Sheol is a real place where humans spend their afterlife, awaiting either (1) the resurrection of the righteous from the Paradise side, or (2) the Hades side (a.k.a. “hell”), the side of torment and suffering. And from **Luke 23:43**, we know that when Jesus died, His spirit went to Paradise.

Conclusion #2:

Abraham is in Sheol's Paradise, and we can reasonably assume that so are Daniel, David, and all righteous saints of all time. That's where the righteous await the resurrection.

[42] And he said, 'Jesus, remember me when you come into your kingdom.'

[43] And he (Jesus) said to him, 'Truly, I say to you, today you will be with me in paradise.'"

— Luke 23:42-43

We've been indoctrinated with things the Bible does not teach.

We've always been taught that when we die, we go to "heaven" — as in UP, somewhere in the sky. But that's not what the Bible teaches.

Jesus visited Sheol's Paradise; He did not visit Sheol's Hades, a.k.a. "hell." The misunderstanding stems from a mistranslation between the Greek and English languages.

Below is 1 Peter 3:19. As you read it (in the original Greek), ask yourself, "Where does it say 'Hades'?" It doesn't! All it says is that the spirits are '*in prison*,' and '*having gone, He preached*.' Do you see anything that says "Hades" or "hell"? No!

The imprisoned spirits are related to the account in Genesis 6 and the Flood of Noah.

WHY were these spirits in prison, in Hades, in the first place? That answer can be found in verse 20:

[19] *"...by whom also He went and preached to the spirits in prison, [20] who formerly were disobedient,..."*

— 1 Peter 3:19-20

The context is the time of Noah and the Flood. Noah was obedient, so he was righteous. Abraham was obedient, so he was righteous. However, the rebellious fallen angel-human hybrids — the Nephilim, the Elioud — they were disobedient, and therefore, most definitely, unrighteous.

Jesus did not "preach a sermon of confession and repentance" — that's not what the original Greek means.

Key Point: The Holy Spirit, who empowered Jesus for His earthly mission, was there in Paradise when He arrived. The same Spirit who hovered over the waters in Genesis 1 and who raised Jesus from the dead (Romans 8:11) accompanied Him in this spiritual realm.

Paradise is not the final destination — it's a temporary place for spirits awaiting resurrection.

“If the Spirit of Him who raised Jesus from the dead dwells in you, He who raised Christ Jesus from the dead will also give life to your mortal bodies through His Spirit who dwells in you.”

— Romans 8:11

Conclusion #3:

Jesus, in the Spirit, most certainly went to Sheol's Paradise, as Luke 23:43 confirmed.

What does it mean: “He led captivity captive”?

After Jesus had captured the attention of the heavenly hosts—angels and spiritual beings already assembled in Paradise—they marveled at His victory. But Jesus did not take anyone out of Sheol. The imprisoned spirits in Hades remain there to this day, awaiting final White Throne judgment.

The Greek term “*aichmalōsian*” (Strong's 162e) means “to take captive” or “to captivate.” It describes how Jesus captured their attention; He did not bring them out of Sheol.

This understanding aligns with other biblical references:

- **Jude 1:6** describes angels who left their domain, now held in eternal chains for judgment.
- **2 Peter 2:4-5** speaks of angels held in darkness until judgment.
- **Hebrews 2:16** clarifies that Jesus does not give aid to angels, but to the seed of Abraham—humans.

“He led captivity captive” means that Jesus, in His triumph, demon-

strated His authority. No one from Sheol accompanied Jesus' spirit when He resurrected back to the surface of the earth, nor did anyone other than angels accompany Him up into the heavens at His ascension. And, the imprisoned spirits in Hades are still awaiting their final judgment — and the lake of fire.

Paul's teaching in Ephesians was not about the pre-resurrected Jesus (who rose from Paradise to the surface), but about Jesus' ascension from the earth to the heavens: "*He ascended on high*." This can be a complex and confusing concept, yet Paul's focus was on Jesus' spiritual triumph and His promise to send the Holy Spirit—the Helper—to empower His followers.

Ten days after Jesus' Ascension (Pentecost), the Helper arrived, and spiritual gifts were poured out. **1 Corinthians 12:4-11** lists these gifts, emphasizing that the Holy Spirit empowers them all and distributes them as He wills.

Now remember: It was Jesus Himself who "called" Saul/Paul to ministry. Verse 7 is the tip-off — "*But grace was given to each one of us according to the measure of Christ's gift*."

Paul's passage to the Ephesians was not in the context of the pre-resurrected, pre-ascended Jesus (from Paradise to the surface). It was in the context of Jesus' ascension (from the surface to the heavens: "*He ascended on high*"). This can be confusing; it's a complex concept, and explaining it is challenging even under the best of circumstances.

Now, when Jesus was about to ascend into heaven, He promised that He would soon send "a Helper" — God's Holy Spirit — the subject of this book.

Ten days after Jesus' Ascension (Pentecost), that "Helper" arrived, and He was bearing all sorts of spiritual gifts:

[4] “Now there are varieties of gifts, but the same Spirit; [5] and there are varieties of service, but the same Lord; [6] and there are varieties of activities, but it is the same God who empowers them all in everyone. ... [11] All these are empowered by the same Spirit, who apportions to each one individually as He wills.”

— 1 Corinthians 12:4-11

“He led captivity captive” does not mean that Jesus took “captives/prisoners” when He was resurrected back to the surface of the earth. Nor did anybody from Sheol accompany Him when He ascended into the heavens.

Further, neither did Jesus bring back to the surface of earth—or to heaven on His ascension—any of the righteous dead who to this day remain waiting for the resurrection in Paradise. (Cf. Jude 1:6, 2 Peter 2:4-5, Hebrews 2:16). Instead, the terms used in the original Greek are:

- In English, the Greek “ēchmalōteusen” (Strong’s 161e) means “a captive multitude.” In other words, Jesus captured the attention of a multitude of righteous spirits that were already assembled in Paradise. Alternatively, it *could* refer to the host of dedicated elohim (angels) who escorted Christ back to His divine abode, and the thousands upon thousands who greeted Him upon His arrival.
- In English, the Greek term “aichmalōsian” (Strong’s 162e) means “I take captive,” as in “to captivate.” Jesus captured their attention; they perked up and listened to what Jesus had to say. This also aligns with what I previously stated.

Furthermore, I can say with complete confidence that this passage *does not* refer to demon spirits imprisoned in Hades because those beasts, the disembodied spirits of Nephilim and Elioud, are irre-

deemable — they are ultimately destined for the lake of fire (**Revelation 20:14**).

To the thief on the cross, Jesus did not promise heaven. He promised Paradise — a real location beneath the surface of the earth. (Luke 23:43)

That very day, Jesus descended there Himself. Not to be punished more in Hades, but to announce His triumph on the cross. He fulfilled God's promise in Genesis 3:15, and He confirmed to the righteous in Paradise that their resurrection was sure to happen. Jesus was the firstfruit, and on the day of the Lord when the resurrection of the righteous dead and the “changing” of the righteous alive happens, we will all join Jesus—as His heirs—in the (His) First Resurrection.

The Firstfruits of Resurrection

Christ's resurrection was the **firstfruits**.

*“But in fact Christ has been raised from the dead,
the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep.”*

— **1 Corinthians 15:20**

He was the prototype. The first to be raised immortal. And His rising ensures ours.

Those who died in faith — Abraham, Sarah, Moses, Ruth — they all await that day.

They remain in Sheol's Paradise, preserved and assured. But Christ has *broken the seal*.

He led the way back to the surface — He proved it would be done.



READ & Discuss

1. **Biblical Support:** What other passages besides John 3:13 and Acts 2:34 support the idea that no one has ascended to heaven except Jesus?
2. **Nature of Sheol:** How do the descriptions of Sheol's two compartments compare to Jewish intertestamental literature (e.g., 1 Enoch, 4 Ezra) and early Christian writings?
3. **Role of the Holy Spirit:** What role does the Holy Spirit play in Sheol's Paradise according to Genesis 1:2, Romans 8:11, and other scriptures?
4. **1 Peter 3:19 Context:** How do scholars interpret Jesus 'preaching' to the spirits in prison? What is the range of views?
5. **Implications for Resurrection:** How does the view that Sheol's Paradise is the temporary abode for the righteous shape our understanding of bodily resurrection and the Day of the Lord?

THE BLESSED HOPE IS RESURRECTION

THE TREE OF LIFE'S PRESENCE IN SHEOL'S PARADISE: THE ANCHOR OF HOPE

In the earliest days—before there was writing—there was myth. Myths were not lies; they were the first compass of humanity, guiding people through mystery and meaning, passed down from one generation to the next. Long before the written word, memory itself preserved the conviction that there is a world beyond death.

The Hebrew Scriptures affirm this conviction. Sheol was not the end—nor a place of annihilation—but a realm beneath the earth, a place of waiting. Within Sheol, there were two compartments: Paradise, a place of comfort for the righteous; and Hades, a place of torment for the wicked. These echoes of Sheol's reality resonate in the oldest poetry of the Psalms, in the cries of Job, and in every ancient culture that spoke of a journey beneath the earth.

Even after Adam and Eve's expulsion from Eden, the Spirit of God did not depart. Eden was sealed, but Paradise was not. The Tree of Life, once rooted in Eden, stood deep within Sheol's Paradise as a silent witness to God's faithfulness and a sign that His Spirit had not

abandoned the righteous dead. The Spirit hovered in Sheol's depths—a river of life flowing unseen, sustaining those who waited in faith.

From Adam to Abraham, from patriarchs to prophets, the stories of Sheol's Paradise traveled like embers of hope through the generations. These ancient memories, preserved in myth and memory, remind us that God's Spirit was never absent. Paradise was not silent, nor was it empty. It was a place of spiritual communion—a waiting room for glory.

Even as the written word arrived with cuneiform around 2,500 BC, oral tradition carried forward these ancient truths. The modern scholarly consensus places Creation around 5,500 BC, leaving nearly three thousand years of human life preserved by memory alone.

Myth does not imply falsehood any more than writing guarantees truth. These ancient whispers echo an enduring conviction: that death would not have the last say.

The Tree of Life in Sheol's Paradise was more than a memory of Eden. It was a living sign of God's abiding Spirit—a promise of future glory. Scripture itself affirms this hope:

*"If I ascend to heaven, you are there!
If I make my bed in Sheol, you are there!"*
— Psalm 139:8

*"Oh, that You would hide me in Sheol,
that You would conceal me until Your wrath be past..."*
— Job 14:13

This hope was a deliberate extension of God's mercy. It resonates in every ancient culture, in the stories of the first families of the earth, and in the silent witness of the Tree's presence.

From the river valleys to the dawn of human civilization, the Tree's testimony endured—rooted deep within Sheol's Paradise as an anchor for the faithful. Even today, myth and memory remain essential.

Mythology is the collected body of these stories—woven together, passed down through oral tradition, shaping the worldview of a people. It is a window into how ancient cultures understood life, death, and the divine.

These stories—echoed in myth—remind us that God's Spirit was never diminished or hidden away. It streamed forth as a river of living water, flowing unseen beneath the surface of the world. The Tree of Life stands as a signpost of this hope: a living witness to God's faithfulness.

In Sheol's Paradise, the righteous dead wait in the embrace of the Spirit, awaiting the day when all will be restored.

White Robes — Symbolic, Not Yet Glorified

Some interpret the white robes of Revelation 6:9-11 as glorified, immortal bodies. But Scripture suggests otherwise. The robes symbolize purity, vindication, and readiness for priestly service. The righteous dead in Paradise are not yet clothed in imperishable glory—they await that Day of the Lord.

As we look back through the mist of myth and memory, we see that Sheol was never simply a realm of shadows. It was a sanctuary—a place where the Tree of Life stood, where the Spirit of God hovered as a river of light, sustaining those who waited in faith. These ancient whispers were not fables; they were faithful echoes of a promise that death would not be the end.

And so we turn to Sheol's hidden depths, to the silent witness of the Tree of Life standing in Paradise—where even in the stillness of the grave, the breath of God's Spirit was present and unwavering. Let us journey onward to explore this resting place of the righteous and the quiet corridors where the faithful await the dawn of glory.



Reflect & Discuss

1. **The Role of Myth in Human Memory** How does the chapter's perspective on myth as a *faithful vessel of memory* reshape your understanding of early human spirituality? What parallels do you see between the ancient mythic memory and modern expressions of faith?
2. **The Tree of Life in Sheol's Paradise** How does the chapter's view of the Tree of Life as an *ever-present anchor of God's Spirit* deepen your understanding of divine continuity—especially in a realm like Sheol? In what ways does this challenge or expand your prior view of Sheol?
3. **The Spirit's Faithful Presence.** The text emphasizes that God's Spirit was never absent from the world, even in the depths of Sheol. How does this idea encourage or strengthen your faith? Have you ever experienced or recognized a “hidden river” of God's Spirit under challenging seasons of life?
4. **The Echo of Eden** This chapter draws a continuous line from Eden to Sheol to the promise of resurrection. How does this narrative arc shape your understanding of God's redemptive plan? How does the enduring witness of the Tree of Life speak to the hope of *resurrection*?
5. **The Value of Memory and Storytelling** The chapter suggests that memory—whether through myth, poetry, or scripture—holds divine truth even in the absence of written word. What role does this perspective give to oral traditions in your own spiritual life? How might you embrace “myth as memory” to better connect with the truths of Scripture?

THE RIGHTEOUS DEAD AND THE PRESENCE OF THE TREE

SHEOL'S PARADISE, WHERE THE RIGHTEOUS
DEAD AWAIT THE RESURRECTION

Long before the written word, there were whispers of the afterlife—echoes of a realm beyond mortal sight, yet never far from the human heart. Passed down through generations, these stories spoke of a hidden place beneath the earth: Sheol. It was no fable, but the soul's quiet testimony to a reality beyond the veil.

Two realms held the souls of the dead: one of torment, a prison for the unrepentant; the other, a realm of peace and promise for the righteous. In the heart of this hidden Paradise stood the Tree of Life—a silent witness to God's faithfulness, its roots reaching deep into creation's foundation, its branches whispering the Spirit's unwavering presence.

"If I ascend to heaven, you are there! If I make my bed in Sheol, you are there!"

— Psalm 139:8

Even in Sheol's depths, the Spirit of God hovered—a river of life,

flowing unseen but unceasing, sustaining those who waited in faith. From Adam to Abraham, from the ancient patriarchs to the prophets, this hope coursed like a hidden stream: that the faithful dead were not abandoned.

The Tree of Life was not merely a memory of Eden; it was a living sign that God's Spirit had never withdrawn. Its presence in Paradise testifies to a promise: that death is not the final word.

The Tree's Silent Witness

The Tree of Life, standing tall in Sheol's Paradise, is more than a remnant of Eden's garden. It is a living witness to the enduring faithfulness of God, an unbroken thread that stretches from creation's dawn to the final resurrection. Its branches, ever-reaching, whisper the promise of restoration, of life beyond the grave. Its roots, hidden deep in the soil of creation, drink from the river of the Spirit—an eternal current that defies decay and defeat.

Here, in the waiting chamber of the righteous, the Tree of Life is not a myth or a legend. It is a signpost of divine presence, a testament to the Spirit's unwavering nearness. In Sheol's quiet corridors, the Tree's silent witness proclaims: death is not the end, and the faithful dead are not forgotten.

A River That Never Ceases

Even in the stillness of Sheol's Paradise, the Spirit's river flows. Unseen, unstoppable, it carries the breath of God into the darkness, sustaining the righteous who rest in faith. From Adam's first breath to the last of the prophets, this river has never ceased its course. It is the promise of life woven into the foundations of creation—a river of light, a river of life, ever fresh, ever faithful.

This is the hope of the righteous dead: that the river of the Spirit does not dry up, nor is the Tree of Life uprooted. Together, they bear witness to the King who will come, the One who will call the sleeping saints to rise in glory.

Scriptural Echoes of the Living Hope

“For you will not abandon my soul to Sheol, or let your holy one see corruption.”

— **Psalms 16:10**

“He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches. To the one who conquers, I will grant to eat of the tree of life, which is in the paradise of God.”

— **Revelation 2:7**

A Foretaste of the Resurrection

In this hidden Paradise, the saints await the final trumpet—the call of the King that will awaken them from their rest. The Tree of Life, rooted deep and nourished by the river of the Spirit, stands as a silent promise: the exile will end, the curse will be reversed, and life will triumph over death.

The righteous dead do not wait in vain. Their hope is anchored in the eternal faithfulness of God, and in the day when the King will descend, they will rise—clothed in light, crowned with immortality. The Tree of Life will no longer stand only in Paradise’s shadow; it will stretch its branches in the New Jerusalem, where God’s presence will be the eternal light.

The Promise of Paradise: A Place of Comfort and Rest

This hidden realm—Sheol’s Paradise—is no mere shadow of a

bygone garden. It is a waiting room of hope, where the righteous find rest in the embrace of the King's Spirit. Here, beyond the reach of mortal sight, the faithful dead are not forgotten. Their cries have been heard. Their faith has not been in vain.

In Sheol's Paradise, the Tree of Life stands as a pledge that the promise of resurrection will not fail. It speaks to the righteous dead: *You are not abandoned. You are not forsaken. Your God is near.*

A Living Current: The Spirit's Presence Across the Ages

The river of the Spirit that waters the Tree of Life has never stopped flowing. From Eden's first river to the headwaters of Sheol's Paradise, this living current weaves through the ages, an unbroken witness to the Creator's faithfulness.

- In the days of Noah, it carried the promise of a remade world.
- In the days of Abraham, it nourished the faith of a sojourner who looked for a city whose builder is God.
- In the days of the prophets, it was a hidden wellspring of hope in a dry and weary land.

Even now, in Sheol's Paradise, the river flows—unseen, unstoppable—sustaining those who have died in faith, anchoring them in the Spirit's abiding presence.

Echoes of Eden, Hints of the Future

The Tree of Life and the river that flows through Paradise are more than memories of Eden. They are signposts of what is yet to come: the promise of a renewed creation, the restoration of all things in the New Jerusalem.

For the righteous dead, Paradise is not the end of the story. It is a foretaste of the garden to come. One day, the trumpet will sound. The King will return. And the Tree of Life will stand in the midst of a new heaven and a new earth, its fruit feeding the redeemed of every nation.

A Final Word of Hope

In the stillness of Sheol's Paradise, there is no despair. There is only the quiet confidence of the Spirit's presence—whispering that death is but a doorway, that the river of life still flows, and that the Tree's branches will soon shade the redeemed in the glory of the King.

Until that day, the righteous dead rest secure. Their hope is sure, for the Spirit of God has never stopped moving, never stopped sustaining, never stopped preparing the world for the day when the curse will be reversed, and the garden will be restored.

A Prayer of Praise and Hope

Lord God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, You who hold the righteous in the embrace of Your Spirit, We thank You for Your faithfulness through the ages.

Thank You for the Tree of Life, the river of Your Spirit, And the promise that death is not the final word.

May we be anchored in this hope — That the righteous dead rest in Your presence, That the river of life still flows unseen, That the day of resurrection draws near.

Strengthen our faith until that day. Remind us that the garden will be restored, The exile reversed, and the curse undone.

May we live as those who trust in Your unending mercy, Ever praising Your name for the inevitable victory.

In the name of the One who conquered death — Our King, Jesus the Christ

— Amen.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. In what ways did the righteous compartment of Sheol (Paradise) serve as a place of comfort and anticipation for the faithful who died before Christ's resurrection?
2. How does understanding the Tree of Life's presence in Sheol's Paradise challenge or reinforce your view of God's Spirit in the afterlife?
3. Discuss the contrast between the righteous and unrighteous compartments of Sheol. What does this reveal about God's justice and mercy?
4. Reflect on how the hope of resurrection and reunification with Christ shapes your understanding of Paradise as not a final rest, but a place of waiting and preparation.
5. How does this chapter encourage you to live with the same hope and anticipation as those who have already entered Paradise?

SHEOL'S SECRETS AND THE COSMIC BATTLE

THE TREE'S EVER-PRESENT WITNESS AND THE RIVER OF LIFE

Sheol — the underworld of the ancient Hebrews — is often portrayed as a place of silence and finality. Yet even there, the presence of God is not absent.

“If I ascend to heaven, you are there! If I make my bed in Sheol, you are there! If I take the wings of the morning and dwell in the uttermost parts of the sea, even there your hand shall lead me, and your right hand shall hold me.”

— Psalm 139:8–10

This verse highlights God’s omnipresence — even in Sheol, His Spirit is present and victorious!

From Eden’s river to Sheol’s depths, the Spirit of God flows unceasingly, a river of life that defies decay and death. In this dark realm, a cosmic battle rages — a war of rebellion and redemption, of ancient principalities and the ultimate triumph of the King.

The River and the Tree: Restoration in the Spirit

“Then the angel showed me the river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb through the middle of the street of the city; also, on either side of the river, the tree of life with its twelve kinds of fruit, yielding its fruit each month.”

— Revelation 22:1-2

What began in Eden did not end with Adam’s exile. The river of life that once watered the garden still flows—unbroken, uncontainable, unstoppable. From Eden to Paradise, through the ages and across the veil of Sheol, the river has carried the promise of divine restoration. Its headwaters is the presence of the Lord Himself.

“And wherever the river goes, every living creature that swarms will live, and there will be very many fish. For this water goes there, that the waters of the sea may become fresh; so everything will live where the river goes.”

— Ezekiel 47:9

The Tree of Life is a living witness to God’s abiding Spirit. Wherever the Tree stands, the river flows. Life flows. Healing flows. The Garden was not a myth, nor was Paradise an illusion. They are real places, real promises, anchored in the reality of God’s presence. This river is the Spirit of God—ever fresh, ever renewing, ever proclaiming that death is not the final word.

The exile of Adam is reversed. The saints reign. The Tree—once guarded by a flaming sword—now welcomes the redeemed to eat freely. This is not mere survival or an escape from mortality. It is the restoration of *all* things: the garden, the river, and the glory of the Creator shared with His people.

The King in Our Midst

Ezekiel saw the river in a vision—a river that began beneath the

threshold of the temple, swelling deeper and wider, unstoppable and overflowing. He saw it nourish the barren land and heal the nations. John saw that same river—flowing from the throne of God and the Lamb, crystal-clear and bright as a promise. Along its banks stood the Tree of Life, bearing fruit in every season, its leaves for the healing of the nations.

This is the inheritance of those who endure in faith. When Jesus returns to reign, the river will not be a mere symbol—it will be a flood of life, an outpouring of divine presence in the New Creation. The Tree will stand in the midst of the city, a testament to God's faithfulness and the Spirit's unending supply.

This is the end of the cosmic battle: the curse reversed, the exile ended, the garden restored. In the presence of the King—Father, Son, and Spirit as One—there will be no more tears, no more night: only light, life, and the eternal peace of God.

The Spirit's River of Life

This final river — more than a symbol — flows with the Spirit's presence and power. At its headwaters is the presence of the Lord Himself, ever-abundant and ever-renewing. In the day when the King's voice shouts and the dead in Christ rise, this river will flow from Paradise to the New Jerusalem, an unbroken stream of life and light.

As we close this chapter, let it be clear: the river of life is not just a promise—it is the Spirit's abiding witness that the restoration of all things is near. It testifies that even in the hidden places of Sheol's Paradise, God's Spirit has never stopped flowing, never stopped sustaining the righteous, and never stopped preparing the world for the return of the King.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. **The River of Life:** How does the imagery of the river of life speak to you personally? What does it mean to you that the river of the Spirit is already flowing in hidden places, sustaining life even before the final restoration?
2. **The Spirit's Presence:** In what ways can we experience the presence of God's Spirit in the "hidden places" of our own lives? How does this encourage you to remain faithful in seasons of waiting?
3. **The Power of the King's Return:** How does the final call of the King—His command to the righteous dead to "come forth"—inspire your hope and faith?
4. **The Unbroken Witness:** The chapter emphasizes that the Spirit has never ceased to flow. How does this challenge or comfort you in your current walk with God?

THE TREE OF LIFE AND THE MILLENNIAL KINGDOM

THE GARDEN RESTORED ON EARTH

Introduction: The Climactic Day

The Day of the Lord is not just a single moment—it is the ultimate unveiling of God’s justice and mercy. In that day, the hidden things will be revealed, and the Tree of Life, long a symbol of hope in Paradise, will stand as a sign of victory in a world restored. This final battle is not fought with earthly weapons, but with the power of God’s Word and the consuming fire of His Spirit.

The cosmic battle will climax on the Day of the Lord, when Christ returns in glory to reign upon the earth. On that day, once hidden in Sheol’s Paradise, the Tree of Life will be revealed again—no longer shrouded in mystery, but standing as a living sign of God’s kingdom.

The Hope of the Millennial Kingdom

This is the hope of the Millennial Kingdom: the curse of death restrained, creation restored to its original splendor.

- **Revelation 20:4-6** promises the resurrection of the righteous—those who share in the “first resurrection” and reign with Christ.
- **Isaiah 65** envisions a renewed earth where the wolf dwells with the lamb and children play without fear.
- **Ezekiel’s vision** (Ezekiel 47) speaks of the river of life flowing from the Temple, bringing healing to the nations—echoing the river that once flowed in Eden.

The Tree of Life’s Restored Role

The Tree of Life, no longer hidden in the depths, becomes the emblem of healing and fruitfulness for all people. **Revelation 22:2** tells of its leaves, given for the healing of the nations. In this thousand-year reign, the Tree stands as a promise: though sin still lingers in the shadows, the Spirit’s life-giving power will bring forth peace, justice, and the foretaste of eternity.

A Beacon of Unity and Healing

During this reign, the Spirit of God—the very breath that gave life to Adam, the river that flows from the throne—will fill the earth. The Tree’s witness is the abiding presence of the Spirit, a beacon of unity and life among those who were once divided. Paradise, once hidden, will be lifted to the surface, and the waiting saints will rejoice in the light of the risen King.

The Millennium’s Bridge to Glory

The Millennium is not the final glory but the bridge between this age and the eternal kingdom. The Tree of Life stands as a living testimony that Eden’s promise has not been lost—it has only been waiting for the Day of the Lord to reveal its full glory.

The Return of Eden's Glory

When Jesus returns in power and glory, the curse of death will be rolled back.

- **Revelation 20:4-6** speaks of the resurrection of the righteous, who reign with Christ.
- **Isaiah 65:17-25** hints at a world renewed, where peace and justice bloom like Eden's garden.
- **Ezekiel's vision of the river of life (Ezekiel 47)** reminds us that water flowing from the Temple brings healing to the land—echoes of the river of life that once flowed in Eden.

The Tree's Presence in the Millennium

The Tree of Life, no longer hidden, becomes the sign of healing and fruitfulness for the nations. Its presence is a promise: the final healing awaits the New Jerusalem.

God Dwelling with His People

During the Millennium, Christ reigns visibly. The Spirit of God, who is the essence of the Tree's life, will fill the earth with the knowledge of the Lord (**Isaiah 11:9**).

- The Tree's witness points to the Spirit's power to bring unity and peace among divided peoples.
- Once beneath the earth, Paradise is now on the surface, the first fruit of a creation reborn.

Conclusion: The Hope of the Millennium

The Tree of Life is not just a memory of Eden—it is the living sign of the coming age. In the Millennium, it will be the abiding presence of

the Spirit—inviting, healing, and drawing all who thirst for the river of life.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. **How does understanding the promise of resurrection and glorification change how you view your own mortality?** *Consider how this promise of renewal and transformation shifts your perspective on death and eternal life.*
2. **What does it mean to you that the same Spirit who raised Jesus will give life to your mortal body?** *Reflect on the personal significance of the Holy Spirit's role in both creation and resurrection.*
3. **How does the Tree of Life, as a symbol of God's Spirit, enrich your understanding of His plan for you?** *Discuss how this ancient symbol resonates with your faith and shapes your anticipation for the future.*

REFUTING POPULAR ERRORS

THE TREE, THE RAPTURE, AND THE RETURN OF THE KING

The Value of Discerning Truth

In every age, myths and errors have arisen to challenge the truth of God's Word. In our time, many popular teachings distort the reality of resurrection, the destiny of the righteous, and the role of the Tree of Life in God's plan.

This chapter aims to set the record straight, confronting widespread misunderstandings and clarifying the hope that Scripture truly reveals.

Error 1: The Tree is Merely Symbolic

Intro: Many assume the Tree of Life is just a poetic or mythic symbol, but scripture shows it as a real spiritual presence.

Key Points:

- The tree's literal existence in Eden (Genesis 2:9).
- Manifestation of God's Shekhinah Glory.

- It continues in Paradise (Revelation 2:7) and reappears in New Jerusalem (Revelation 22:2).
- It is the bridge—tangible and spiritual—between Eden, Paradise, and eternity.

Refutation: It's not merely symbolic; it's a conduit of God's Spirit—a living witness to the power of resurrection.

Error 2: Paradise is Empty

Intro: Some claim Paradise was “emptied” at Christ's resurrection—no longer in use or relevant.

Key Points:

- Jesus' words to the thief on the cross: “Today you will be with me in Paradise” (**Luke 23:43**).
- The *waiting place* for righteous souls remains until the Day of the Lord (**1 Thessalonians 4:13-17**).
- Consistent witness across scripture and early church fathers.

Refutation: Paradise is still occupied by the righteous dead, awaiting the resurrection. The Tree's presence there confirms this as a place of life, not of emptiness.

Error 3: Saints Go to Heaven at Death

Intro: Modern belief: souls go directly to heaven at death. Scripture says otherwise.

Key Points:

- *Soul sleep* vs. Paradise rest—Scripture shows Paradise as the interim place.

- The promise of “resurrection” is future, not immediate.
- **Luke 16**’s story (Lazarus in Abraham’s bosom).

Refutation: Luke 16 is no parable—it’s an accurate prophetic account, spoken by Jesus Himself, about Sheol’s two compartments. The righteous do not immediately ascend to Heaven at death. Instead, they await resurrection in Sheol’s Paradise, under the care of God’s Spirit and in the presence of the Tree of Life. This is a vital truth: the final resurrection will bring them to the renewed earth, not to an ethereal Heaven.

4. Christ’s Return and the Gathering of the Saints

Intro: Pre-trib rapture teachings distort the unity of Christ’s return.

Key Points:

- The Greek terms *apantēsis* and *episunagōgē* (meeting the Lord in the air, being gathered to him, and immediately returning to the earth with Him to reign).
- **1 Thessalonians 4:17** – not a permanent departure to heaven, but a U-turn reunion with Christ.
- **Revelation 19:14** – saints come **with** Christ to earth.

Refutation: Resurrection is a reunion on earth—not an evacuation to heaven. The Tree’s witness in Sheol’s Paradise and its future on earth underscore God’s eternal plan to restore, not to whisk away.

Conclusion: The Power of Discernment

The Tree of Life teaches us to discern truth from error, myth from revelation. In every age, false teachings challenge the hope of resurrection and the promise of new creation. Yet the witness of Scripture remains unbroken: God’s Spirit has never been absent, the faithful

dead have not been forgotten, and the final victory of Christ's kingdom will soon be revealed.



THE TRIUMPH OF RESURRECTION

THE TREE'S WITNESS AND THE CONVERGENCE OF SPIRIT AND FLESH

Introduction: The Day of Victory

Resurrection on the Day of the Lord is the crowning moment when God's promises find physical and spiritual fulfillment. It is the day when the ancient longing of the righteous—waiting in Sheol's Paradise—is met by the power of God's Spirit to renew and transform.

*15 [51] "Behold! I tell you a mystery. We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed, in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet.
[52] For the trumpet will sound, and the dead will be raised imperishable, and we shall be changed."*

— 1 Corinthians 15:51-52

Both the righteous dead who are resurrected and the righteous alive who are "changed" will rise from the surface in our new glorified immortal bodies (like Christ's). We will meet (Gr. *apantēsis*) Christ in the air, be (Gr. *episunagōgē*) gathered to Him, and immediately return to the earth's surface. This is the day of the Lord, when the world sees Christ and His army of *elohim* coming.

It will be our seeing Him on His way that Titus 2:13 addresses — *our blessed hope*.

2 [13] “...waiting for our blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ,...

— Titus 2:13

Why will we be celebrating? Because on this day — the day of the Lord, the righteous dead will be resurrected, and the righteous alive will be “changing” — i.e., we receive our glorified, immortal bodies.

Let there be no confusion: there is only ONE Second Coming, and this is it.

Christ is not coming partway down and making a U-turn to go back up to “heaven.” Nor is He a thief who needs to sneak in and (harpazo) snatch away some human souls. That’s something Satan does, not God!

Instead, this is the day when Christ (Gr. *Parousia*) finally returns to judge His enemies and the enemies of His People. He will reclaim David’s throne, rule His kingdom on earth, and make all things new in preparation for the coming of New Jerusalem.

On this day—the day of the Lord—the righteous will rush out to greet our returning King. We will make the U-turn and return with Christ to the earth, and we will be forever with Him.

4 [16] “For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a cry of command, with the voice of an archangel, and with the sound of the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first. [17] Then we who are alive, who are left, will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air, and so we will always be with the Lord.”

— 1 Thessalonians 4:16-17

As it was on Palm Sunday, so it will be on the day of the Lord. The crowd will rush out to greet the King, and then they will return into the city with Him.

Christ never returns to the heavens. The Kingdom of Heaven — the Kingdom of God — is here, on earth.

When the earth is restored to its Edenic state, the Father will deliver New Jerusalem to the earth.

The heavens will pass away, and God — Father, Son, and Holy Spirit — will dwell with the righteous on this planet.

Just as God intended from the beginning — establishing the physical realm, setting His throne on “the mountain of God,” making the garden on the mountain’s east side, and creating Adam and Eve to be fruitful and multiply — so all of humanity could enjoy the blessings of communing with Him.

3 [20] “...our citizenship is in heaven, and from it we await a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ, [21] Who will transform our lowly body to be like His glorious body....”

— **Philippians 3:20-21**

The Return of the Spirit to the Body

This hope is not merely spiritual but fully embodied: the soul and spirit will be clothed in new, imperishable flesh. This promise, rooted in God’s covenant, is the heartbeat of the triumph over death.

[42] “So is it with the resurrection of the dead. What is sown is perishable; what is raised is imperishable. [43] It is sown in dishonor; it is raised in glory. It is sown in weakness; it is raised in power. [44] It is sown a natural body and raised a spiritual body.”

— **1 Corinthians 15:42-44**

The reuniting of the human spirit with the body will complete God's promise: "death is swallowed up in victory" (1 Corinthians 15:54). This final defeat of death—spirit and flesh in perfect harmony—ushers in the dawn of the new creation, where death will no longer reign.

This triumph is not an abstract hope but a living reality. It is the day when the fullness of life conquers the final enemy and creation is reborn in the likeness of Christ's resurrection.

The Tree's Role in Resurrection

Throughout the ages, the Tree of Life has been more than a symbol; it is the abiding presence of God's Spirit. When the time comes, the Tree will stand as a beacon of comfort, echoing the Shekhinah Glory of God that watched over the waiting righteous throughout the ages.

22 [1] "Then the angel showed me the river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb [2] through the middle of the street of the city; also, on either side of the river, the Tree of Life with its twelve kinds of fruit, yielding its fruit each month. The eaves of the tree are for the healing of the nations.

— **Revelation 22:1-2**

No longer hidden behind the cherubim's sword (Genesis 3:24), the Tree's witness flows like a river of life, proclaiming that death has been conquered and creation is reborn (Isaiah 25:8).

21 [2] "And I saw the holy city, New Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride adorned for her husband. [3] And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying, 'Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man...'"

— **Revelation 21:2-3**

The Firstfruits of Resurrection

Christ's resurrection is the firstfruits of all who will share in the Tree's promise. He rose as the pioneer of the new creation, the first to wear the glory of the resurrection body. His victory is not isolated but guarantees that the same Spirit who raised Him will raise us also.

15 [20] "...Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep.

— 1 Corinthians 15:20

Christ was the first of the firstfruits, but because the righteous are heirs of Christ's, we share in that "first-" honor. Therefore, on the day of the Lord when the righteous are resurrected from Sheol's Paradise, they/we too are part of the Firstfruits.

The Tree of Life is the testament to this promise: that the firstfruits are only the beginning of the full redemption of all who are in Him.

15 [21] For as by a man came death, by a man has come also the resurrection of the dead. [22] For as in Adam all die, so also in Christ shall all be made alive. [23] But each in his own order: Christ the firstfruits, then at His coming those who belong to Christ. [24] Then comes the end, when He delivers the kingdom to God the Father after destroying every rule, authority, and power. [25] For He must reign until He has put all his enemies under His feet. [26] The last enemy to be destroyed is death."

— 1 Corinthians 15:21-26

Clothed in glory, raised to reign with Him in the Millennial Kingdom.

20 [4] "Then I saw thrones, and seated on them were those to whom the authority to judge was committed. Also, I saw the souls of those who had been beheaded for the testimony of Jesus and for the word of God, and those who had not worshiped the beast or its image and had not received its mark

on their foreheads or their hands. They came to life and reigned with Christ for a thousand years.

— **Revelation 20:4**

A Glimpse of the Age to Come

The Millennium itself is but a foretaste—a bridge between this present age and the eternal kingdom of God (**Isaiah 65:17-25**).

20 [5] The rest of the dead did not come to life until the thousand years were ended. This is the first resurrection. [6] Blessed and holy is the one who shares in the first resurrection!

— **Revelation 20:5-6**

The final unveiling awaits the New Jerusalem, where the Tree of Life will stand forever as a beacon of healing and flourishing for all creation (**Revelation 21:1-4; Revelation 22:1-3**). The resurrection of the righteous signals the dawn of a renewed creation, but the final unveiling awaits the New Jerusalem, where the Tree of Life will stand forever in the heart of God's city (**Revelation 21:1-4; Revelation 22:1-3**).

As the Day of the Lord unfolds, the promise of resurrection merges with the final hope of God's kingdom—a new creation where the righteous will dwell in God's presence, no longer hindered by sin or death. The Tree of Life, once a silent witness in Sheol's Paradise, will stand openly in the New Jerusalem as the eternal testament of healing and life.

In the next chapter, we will hear the Spirit's final invitation to "Come and drink"—an invitation to share in the river of life, where the Bride of Christ will drink deeply from the fountain of God's glory.

22 [5] "And night will be no more. They will need no light of lamp or sun, for the Lord god will be their light, and they will reign forever and ever."

— **Revelation 22:5**

This is the hope that binds all ages: the promise of a new creation where the righteous will dwell with God forever, no longer hindered by sin or death. The Tree of Life, once a silent witness in Sheol's Paradise, will stand openly in the New Jerusalem as a beacon of healing and eternal life. And as this chapter closes, we hear the Spirit's final invitation: "Come and drink"—a call to share in the river of life and drink deeply from the fountain of God's glory, clothed in glory and raised to reign with Him in the Millennial Kingdom.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. Why is the resurrection of the righteous more than just a return to life, but a transformation of life itself? *Consider the promise of imperishable, glorified bodies and how this echoes the original intent for humanity in Eden.*
2. How does the union of soul, spirit, and body in resurrection reflect the triune nature of God? *Explore how our resurrection is a reflection of God's own image and His promise to restore us fully.*
3. In what ways does this final victory over death anchor your hope today? *Share how this future promise shapes your faith and perspective on daily struggles or losses.*

THE KING'S CALL TO MUSTER — THE LAST TRUMPET

THE DAY OF THE LORD'S TRIUMPHANT TRUMPET

From the moment Eden's gate closed,
the promise of restoration began.

23 [43] *"Truly, I say to you, today you will be with me in paradise."* —
Luke 23:43

For seven thousand years, the Spirit's Shekhinah Glory has illuminated and sustained the righteous in Paradise:

21 [23] *"...for the glory of God gives it light..."*
— Revelation 21:23

2 [7] *"To the one who conquers I will grant to eat of the tree of life, which is in the paradise of God."*
— Revelation 2:7

Paul, writing in Titus, captured this long-awaited expectation—the blessed hope that has sustained the faithful through the ages...

2 [13] “...in the present age, [13] waiting for our blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ,...”

— Titus 2:13

And then, the final signs of the King’s arrival explode across the heavens:

24 [29] “Immediately after the tribulation of those days, the sun will be darkened, and the moon will not give its light, and the stars will fall from heaven, and the powers of the heavens will be shaken.”

— Matthew 24:29

Suddenly, the loudspeakers of Sheol ring out, echoing Joel’s ancient prophecy...

2 [31] “The sun shall be turned to darkness, and the moon to blood, before the great and awesome day of the Lord comes.”

— Joel 2:31

The righteous spirits in Paradise all took courage, recalling Psalm 73...

73 [24] “You guide me with your counsel, and afterward you will receive me to glory.”

— Psalm 73:24

The King’s Call to Muster — The Sound of the Last Trumpet

First, the heavens open. Then, at the sound of the trumpet, the first resurrection begins:

19 [11] “Then I saw heaven opened, and behold, a white horse! The one sitting on it is called Faithful and True... [14] And the armies of heaven, arrayed in fine linen, white and pure, were following him on white horses.”

— Revelation 19:11-14

4 “[16] For the Lord himself will descend from heaven with a **cry of command**, with the voice of an archangel, and with the sound of the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first.”

— **1 Thessalonians 4:16**

24 [31] “And he will send out his angels with a loud trumpet call, and they will **gather his elect** from the four winds, from one end of heaven to the other.”

— **Matthew 24:31**

And then, the righteous spirits in Paradise—and the faithful still alive on earth—will leap with joy, for the promise is at last fulfilled...

4 [16] “For the Lord himself will descend from heaven with a cry of command, with the voice of an archangel, and with the sound of the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first. [17] Then we who are alive, who are left, will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air, and so we will always be with the Lord.”

— **1 Thessalonians 4:16-17**

Paul described this glorious transformation in a mystery revealed:

15 [51] “Behold! I tell you a mystery. We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed, in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet. [52] For the trumpet will sound, and the dead will be raised imperishable, and we shall be changed. [53] For this perishable body must put on the imperishable, and this mortal body must put on immortality.”

— **1 Corinthians 15:51-53**

And just like that, Paradise fell silent—its light extinguished. The Tree of Life and every righteous spirit had ascended. Back to the surface they went, rejoined with their Lord and Savior—King Christ.

The Unrighteous Will Realize the Moment, Too

Meanwhile, every unrighteous soul in Sheol's Hades will grasp the gravity of this moment, too:

6 [12] "When he opened the sixth seal, I looked, and behold, there was a great earthquake, and the sun became black as sackcloth, the full moon became like blood, [13] and the stars of the sky fell to the earth...[14] The sky vanished like a scroll that is being rolled up, and every mountain and island was removed from its place."

— **Revelation 6:12-14**

And so, too, will the unrighteous on the surface come to understand:

6 [15] "Then the kings of the earth and the great ones and the generals and the rich and the powerful, and everyone, slave and free, hid themselves in the caves and among the rocks of the mountains, [16] calling to the mountains and rocks, 'Fall on us and hide us from the face of Him who is seated on the throne, and from the wrath of the Lamb, [17] for the great day of their wrath has come, and who can stand?'"

— **Revelation 6:15-17**

The Final Tree is Rooted in the First Tree — the Tree of Life

The Restoration Series is about our resurrection and **restoration** — not only of ourselves through redemption on Calvary's Tree, but also of the planet's restoration in preparation for the arrival of New Jerusalem.

From Eden to Calvary and from Jesus' Cross to Sheol's Paradise to The Kingdom of God, and ultimately to eternity in New Jerusalem.

The Tree of Life — the Shekhinah Glory of God's Holy Spirit — was planted and bears fruit in us.

We were lost in Adam. We are found in Christ. We were exiled by disobedience. God's grace redeems us.

And so, as the heavens open and the King descends, the righteous are raised, and Paradise is emptied. The stage is set for the restoration of all things, and the promise of the Tree of Life begins to blossom.

22 [2b-c] “...*the Tree of Life ... The leaves of the tree are for the healing of the healing of the nations.*”

— Revelation 22:2b-c



Reflect & Discuss

1. What is the significance of the Shekhinah's embrace and its restoration through Christ's obedience?
2. How does the Tree of Life reflect the ongoing presence of God's Spirit in creation and redemption?
3. In what ways does the Sabbath rest point to the final restoration in New Jerusalem?
4. How can the hope of the Tree of Life's healing power reshape our daily walk and spiritual perspective?

THE TREE'S LIFE-GIVING FRUIT — THE FINAL HARVEST

A CELEBRATION OF RESTORATION AND
HEALING

In the beginning, Adam stood before the Tree of Life. It was filled with God's Shekhinah Glory — His Holy Spirit. Meanwhile, Eve's eyes lusted after the low-hanging forbidden fruit of the tree of knowledge of good and evil. God had commanded them not to so much as touch that tree, let alone eat its poisonous fruit. Well, you know the story.

The serpent (Heb. *nahash*) deceived Eve, and she ate the forbidden fruit. What made it even worse: Adam — the first human created in the image and likeness of Elohim — joined her in the sin. Adam and Eve proved to be naively disloyal to God.

NOTE: Psalm 82 - Author's Privilege

Here, I will present a theory: God created Adam in the image and likeness of God (Elohim) and the *elohim* ("sons of God").

Attributes of bodies of *elohim* (**Psalm 104:4**) — winds, flaming fire; (**Genesis 18-19**) — can manifest as humans when on specific assignments from God; not subject to disease, death, or decay; immortal; (**Luke 2:9**) — may radiate God's Shekhinah Glory; (**2 Kings**

19:35) — superior power, struck down 185,000 Assyrians; absolute loyalty and obedient to God's commands.

In Psalm 82, God and His divine council are trying lesser elohim for the crime of corrupt mal-governance of their assigned territories on the earth. Found guilty, God announces their punishment: [6] *"I said, 'You are gods, sons of the Most High, all of you; [7] nevertheless, like men you shall die, and fall like any prince."*

This author's theory is that, as initially designed, although Adam was composed of the dust of the earth, he may have had attributes similar to those of elohim. As the bodies of the convicted angels were demoted to bodies like men, Adam may have suffered a similar consequence. I have no proof of this — it is presented here as "food for thought."

The Tree that Became The Cross

In the fullness of time — some 5,500 years after Adam's "fall," Jesus stood before a different Tree. Jesus, Son of Man, obeyed — even unto death.

2 [8] *"And being found in human form, He humbled Himself by becoming obedient to the point of death
— even death on a cross."
— Philippians 2:8*

The Tree of the Cross was more than a place of death; it was the seedbed of new creation. The New Covenant — Jesus became the seed sown in weakness, raised in power.

From Him came forth the promise of fruit that nourishes the resurrected and the glorified.

As John wrote:

15 [43] "It is sown in dishonor; it is raised in glory. It is sown in weakness; it is raised in power. [44] It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body... [45] Thus it is written, 'The first man Adam became a living being'; the last Adam became a life-giving spirit."

— 1 Corinthians 15:43

The Tree of Life is the Shekhinah's Embrace

The Shekhinah's Embrace is the heartbeat of the Tree of Life's promise — the radiant presence of God Himself, His Holy Spirit dwelling among His people in full glory.

In Eden, the Shekhinah light bathed the Tree of Life, illuminating the garden with the beauty of divine communion. After Adam's fall, that brilliance was veiled, and the world was cast into shadows.

Yet, through the obedience of Christ, the Temple's veil was torn, and the Shekhinah glory shines again.

To be embraced by the Shekhinah is to be enveloped in the warmth of God's eternal light — His Spirit. His brilliance of holiness and His life-giving power flow like a river of living water (**Revelation 21:22-22:5**). It is to be infused with His Spirit, participating in the radiance that sustains and restores all creation.

In the resurrection, the Shekhinah's light becomes the light of every redeemed soul.

The Tree of Life's branches are blanketed with divine glory, and its fruit nourishes the righteous. No longer distant or out of sight, the Shekhinah embraces the faithful and reminds us of His promise of everlasting communion with the One who is Light and Life.

The Sabbath Rest

The Sabbath rest in Sheol's Paradise is but a shadow of the eternal Sabbath awaiting in New Jerusalem. Here, the Tree of Life stands in perpetual light, sustaining the nations with its fruit and healing leaves. The Shekhinah glory bathes the Holy City, a river of life flowing from the throne of God.

Yet even this eternal rest is not the end of our calling. On the Day of the Lord, the holiday of rest will be over. It will be time for the righteous to rise as heirs and join the King in restoring the earth. A thousand years of labor and transformation will prepare creation to receive New Jerusalem, the dwelling place of God among men.

We will join the One who conquered on the Tree, and we will help Him fulfill the promise first spoken at Eden's gate.

Cursed Is Everyone Who Hangs on a Tree

3 [13] *"Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us — for it is written, 'Cursed is everyone who is hanged on a tree.'"*

— Galatians 3:13

In the language of Scripture, the Cross was a tree.

21 [23] *"...his body shall not remain all night on the tree... for a hanged man is cursed by God."*

— Deuteronomy 21:23

Jesus bore the curse for all of humanity's sins. He reversed Eden. He became the seed who would crush the serpent.

3 [15] *"...He shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise His heel." —*

Genesis 3:15

The Tree of the Cross was the Tree of Victory.

Not Just a Death — A Planting

12 [24] *“Unless a grain of wheat falls into the earth and dies, it remains alone; but if it dies, it bears much fruit.”*

— John 12:24

Jesus was the grain that was sown in the grave. And through His resurrection will come a harvest of life.

15 [20] *“...Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep.”*

— 1 Corinthians 15:20

The First —the fruit of life renewed, was the beginning of glorification, for all who are in Him.

The Tree and the Throne Are One

In Revelation, the story comes full circle...

2 [7] *“To the one who conquers I will grant to eat of the Tree of Life, which is in the paradise of God.”*

— Revelation 2:7

How do we overcome? How do we conquer? By following the example of the Lamb of God. By walking the path of obedience. By trusting *in* the One who hung on the Tree and in the eternal life He promised. If only we would endure — even unto death.

12 [10] *“And I heard a loud voice in heaven saying, ‘Now the salvation and the power and the kingdom of our God and the authority of His Christ have come, for the accuser of our brothers has been thrown down, who accuses them day and night before our God. [11] ‘And they conquered him by the*

*blood of the Lamb and the word of their testimony, for they loved not their
lives even unto death.” ”*

— **Revelation 12:10-11**

The Tree of the Cross is where *death to self* results in eternal life in His presence. Be an overcomer. Conquer the (Heb.) *śāṭān*.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. How does the curse of the Tree of the Cross transform our understanding of the Tree of Life?
2. In what ways does Christ's resurrection as the *firstfruits* guarantee our own resurrection and victory over death?
3. How does the theme of *planting and harvest* help us see the Cross as more than a symbol of death?
4. How can we live daily in light of the eternal life and restoration promised through the Tree of Life?

LIFE IMMORTAL

GLORIFIED SAINTS, RESURRECTION, AND ETERNAL UNION

20 [6] *“Blessed and holy is the one who shares in the first resurrection! Over such the second death has no power, but they will be priests of God and of Christ, and they will reign with him for a thousand years.”*

— Revelation 20:6

From Paradise to Glory

The Tree of Life, once hidden in Eden and later accessed by faith in Sheol’s Paradise, will one day be available to all the righteous in glorified form. The saints who have waited in Abraham’s bosom, drinking deeply of the presence of God, now rise in **the First Resurrection** — transformed, immortal, and radiant.

12 [3] *“Those who are wise shall shine like the brightness of the sky above; and those who turn many to righteousness, like the stars forever and ever.”*

— Daniel 12:3

This is a **bodily resurrection**, foretold by the prophets and inaugurated by Christ Himself. His resurrection is the **firstfruits**, and those who belong to Him will follow at His appearing (**1 Corinthians 15:23**).

The Nature of Immortality

Immortality in Scripture is not merely **unending existence** — it is **unending existence in union with God**, through a glorified, incorruptible body. The resurrection body is sown perishable, raised imperishable; sown in dishonor, raised in glory.

3 [21] *“He will transform our lowly body to be like his glorious body, by the power that enables him even to subject all things to himself.”*

— **Philippians 3:21**

These glorified saints, raised with Christ, are no longer subject to decay or death. They are **like Him** — clothed in light, bearing His name, and reigning with Him in the Kingdom of God.

Access to the Tree of Life

In Eden, Adam was **exiled from the Tree**. In Paradise, the righteous awaited its fullness. In the Kingdom, the glorified saints **inherit the Tree** — not symbolically, but truly. This is their reward.

Heiser puts it this way:

“The Tree of Life is about access to divine presence — to immortality. Adam lost it. Christ restores it. But it comes not in Eden, not in death, but at resurrection.”

— *Unseen Realm*, Ch. 3

12 [7] *“To the one who conquers I will grant to eat of the tree of life, which is in the paradise of God.”*

— **Revelation 2:7**

Priests and Kings

Scripture repeatedly affirms that those who share in the resurrection will also share in Christ's reign:

- *"They will be priests of God and of Christ, and they will reign with Him for a thousand years."* (Rev. 20:6)
- *"You have made them a kingdom and priests to our God, and they shall reign on the earth."* (Rev. 5:10)
- *"If we endure, we will also reign with Him."* (2 Timothy 2:12)

This priest-king inheritance reflects the original calling of Adam — who was meant to guard and govern the garden — and the destiny of Israel — called to be a kingdom of priests (Exodus 19:6). In Christ, that promise is **fulfilled in the glorified Church**.

The Garden Restored

The promise that began in Eden does not end in death — it is fulfilled in resurrection. Those who eat from the Tree of Life do so not in myth or metaphor, but in immortal union with Christ. The exile is reversed. The saints reign. And the Tree — once guarded by a flaming sword — is now shared by those made holy. This is restoration.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. What hope does the *first resurrection* offer to those who trust in Christ?
2. How does the Tree of Life's promise of restoration and union with God reveal His faithfulness throughout history?
3. What makes the *resurrection body* more than just a return to life? How does it reveal the glory of union with God?
4. How does the call to be *priests and kings* (Revelation 20:6, 5:10) shape your understanding of your identity and purpose in the age to come?

THE TREE IN THE AGE TO COME

NEW JERUSALEM AND EDEN RESTORED

22 [1] *“Then the angel showed me the river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb [2] through the middle of the street of the city; also, on either side of the river, the tree of life with its twelve kinds of fruit, yielding its fruit each month. The leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations.”*

— Revelation 22:1–2

The Full-Circle Restoration

The Tree of Life appears again — not hidden behind cherubim or buried beyond Sheol’s veil, but boldly planted at the heart of the eternal city. No longer inaccessible, it now straddles the River of Life flowing from the very throne of God and the Lamb.

What began in Genesis 2 has now come full circle. But this is no mere return. It is a *glorified return* — a spiral ascending from origin to consummation. Eden is not just restored; it is *exalted* — a radiant garden city, saturated in worship, divine light, and global healing. What Adam lost is now the inheritance of the redeemed

Xulon Zōēs — One Tree or Many?

Dr. Michael Heiser offers this insight into the final vision of Revelation:

“The phrase *xulon zōēs* in Greek (‘tree of life’) is most likely collective. We shouldn’t picture a lone tree but a **grove of trees** on both sides of the river. That imagery isn’t new — it goes back to **Ezekiel 47**, where multiple fruit-bearing trees line the river flowing from the restored temple.”

— NB-397: Revelation 21–22

Heiser’s reading aligns perfectly with the plural richness of Revelation 22: twelve fruits, one per month, offered in continual provision. The Tree is not a symbol of static perfection, but of *perpetual abundance*: life that never fades, fruit that never spoils, rhythms that never fail.

The River as the Spirit of God

The river flowing from the throne isn’t just a stream — it is the *Spirit*. A visible sign of divine life proceeding from the Father and the Son, it nourishes the Tree of Life just as in Eden and Ezekiel’s vision.

In Ezekiel 47, the river begins as a trickle beneath the threshold and becomes a mighty flow — strong enough to swim in, fresh enough to transform saltwater, and powerful enough to make barren trees bear fruit “every month.”

47 [9] “Wherever the river goes, everything will live...”

— Ezekiel 47:9

The Spirit, then, is not merely symbolized — **He is the source**. The Tree of Life thrives because the Spirit dwells there. Where the Spirit abides, death retreats and divine life flows freely.

Healing for the Nations

22[2] *"The leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations."*

— Rev. 22:2

This single line reveals the global scale of restoration. Not just individuals, but *entire nations* are made whole. The Tree of Life, once enclosed in a secluded garden, is now *cosmically public* — accessible to every redeemed tribe that enters the city.

Zechariah foresaw this:

14 [16] *"Then everyone who survives of all the nations... shall go up year after year to worship the King."*

— Zechariah 14:16

It echoes Isaiah 60–66, where former enemies become brothers, bringing praise, wealth, and worship into the New Jerusalem. The Tree is a **banner of shalom**—peace and oneness restored at every level.

No More Curse, No More Night

The following line is almost too rich to rush through:

22 [3] *"No longer will there be anything accursed..."*

— Revelation 22:3

The curse of Genesis 3 — toil, pain, exile, death — is finally lifted. The flaming sword no longer bars the way. God's throne is no longer veiled. And the Tree of Life stands prominently *amidst* the city. There is no night. No need for sun or lamp. The **eternal Shekhinah** is the light—unveiled.

Reigning with Christ Forever

The final sentence of Revelation may be its most understated:

22 [5] *“They will reign forever and ever.”*
— **Revelation 22:5**

The Tree is not only a symbol of *return* — it is a symbol of *rule*. Those who eat of it become **co-regents** — priests and kings, as promised throughout Revelation:

- *“They will be priests of God and Christ...”* (**Revelation 20:6**)
- *“You have made them a kingdom... and they shall reign...”*
(**Revelation 5:10**)
- *“If we endure, we will also reign...”* (**2 Timothy 2:12**)

In this final vision, the Tree of Life is more than a physical tree — it is the radiant presence of the Spirit of God, fulfilling the promise of divine union that began in the Garden of Eden.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. How does the Tree of Life in Revelation go beyond Eden's original in its glory and access? *Consider how the imagery in Revelation reclaims and magnifies the lost glory of Eden.*
2. What does Heiser's insight about the tree as a collective grove suggest about the fullness of life in the age to come? *How might this affect our view of spiritual community?*
3. In what ways does the Tree of Life symbolize the Spirit of God dwelling among His people? *Discuss how the Spirit's presence is like the Tree's healing and abundance.*
4. Why do you think the imagery of twelve fruits, monthly cycles, and healing leaves is so rich? *What does it teach us about God's unending provision and life?*

APPENDIX A - SCRIPTURE LIST

Appendix: Scripture Index

Creation & Eden

Genesis 1:27

Genesis 2:7

Genesis 2:9

Genesis 2:15

Genesis 3:22

Genesis 3:24

The Two Trees

Genesis 2:17

Revelation 2:7

Revelation 22:2

Revelation 22:14

Fall & Exile

Genesis 3:15

Genesis 4:16

Isaiah 59:2

The Cross as Tree

Philippians 2:8

Galatians 3:13

Deuteronomy 21:23

John 12:24

1 Corinthians 15:20

Revelation 2:7

Revelation 12:11

Galatians 2:20

Kingship & Priesthood

Exodus 19:6

Isaiah 61:3

Isaiah 61:6

1 Peter 2:9

Revelation 3:21

Revelation 5:10

Revelation 22:3–4

New Creation & Restoration

Acts 3:21

Revelation 21:1–3

Revelation 22:1–2

Revelation 22:17

APPENDIX B - LUKE 16:19-31 VERSE-BY-VERSE STUDY

v. 22: “Carried by angels to Abraham’s side”

This is not Heaven, as some believe. It is Paradise — the righteous side of Sheol. Located beneath the surface of the earth, not above the clouds. Abraham is not seated in glory; he is waiting. The angels are not delivering souls to heaven, but escorting the righteous dead to Sheol’s Paradise, where they will be comforted.

Takeaway: Paradise is within Sheol — not above the clouds. It is a waiting place, not a reward chamber.

v. 23: “In Hades, being in torment...”

Jesus uses the term Hades — revealing that the unrighteous side is a place of conscious torment, not sleep or annihilation. The rich man sees, feels, speaks, pleads, and remembers.

Takeaway: Conscious torment is real.

v. 24: “Cool my tongue... I am in anguish in this flame.”

The rich man has no physical body. This is not about literal tongues or water — but about the real suffering of the disembodied spirit. The fire is spiritual, not metaphorical.

Takeaway: Hades is different from the lake of fire. Hades is currently occupied, but at the second resurrection — of the unrighteous at the White Throne judgment — both Death and Hades will be consumed in the lake of fire. This happens at the end of Christ's Millennial Reign, and just prior to the arrival of new Jerusalem.

v. 25: "You received your good things..."

Abraham is not merely comforting — he is explaining reversal. This affirms that life's trajectory carries consequences into Sheol. The rich man's exile is not arbitrary; it is just.

Takeaway: The comfort of Paradise cannot be earned by suffering, as some misguided zealots of Roman Catholicism, Shia Islam, and some Hindu sects believe (self-flagellation).

v. 26: "A great chasm has been fixed..."

This is Jesus' most explicit declaration that there is no crossing between Paradise and Hades. There is no purgatory. Finality is set. Upon death, we are judged and found either righteous (Paradise) or unrighteous (Hades). There is no opportunity for redemption after death.

Takeaway: This destroys the notion of post-death repentance. Sheol is partitioned, and the sides are sealed.

vv. 27–31: "Send Lazarus... if someone goes from the dead..."

The rich man begs for a messenger to the living. He thinks a sign or a seance will convince his brothers. Abraham refuses: "If they do not

hear Moses and the Prophets, they will not be persuaded even if someone should rise from the dead.”

T The Word of God is the dividing line. What we think or feel is irrelevant. God’s Word is final.



APPENDIX C - DEEPER STUDY: SHEOL, RESURRECTION, FIRST RESURRECTION

I. Old Testament Passages on Sheol and Resurrection

Sheol and Descent

- **Genesis 37:35** — Jacob says, *“I shall go down to Sheol to my son, mourning.”*
- **Numbers 16:30, 33** — The earth opens, and Korah and his followers go down alive into Sheol.
- **Deuteronomy 32:22** — Speaking of Hades: *“For a fire is kindled by my anger, and it burns to the depths of Sheol.”*
- **Job 7:9** — Speaking of Hades: *“He who goes down to Sheol does not come up.”*
- **Psalms 88:3-6** — Speaking of the bottomless pit - the deepest part of Sheol: *“I am counted among those who go down to the pit... You have put me in the depths of the pit.”*
- **Isaiah 14:9-15** — Lucifer is brought down to Sheol, to the far reaches of the pit.

Ascent and Resurrection Hope

- **Psalm 16:10** — Referring to Hades: *“For you will not abandon my soul to Sheol, or let your holy one see corruption.”*
- **1 Samuel 28:15** — Since there is no possible redemption for condemned souls in Hades, this must refer to the Paradise side. After all, we know that the witch of Endor called UP called Samuel UP from Sheol’s Paradise, disturbing Samuel’s peace: *“Then Samuel said to Saul, ‘Why have you disturbed me by bringing me up?’”* Since Sheol’s Paradise is DOWN relative to the surface of the earth, Samuel was called UP to the surface by the witch at Endor to converse with Saul. (V.19b), *“And tomorrow you and your sons shall be with me (in Sheol).”* Was Saul assigned to Hades? Or to Paradise?
- **Psalm 30:3** — (David) *“You have brought up my soul from Sheol.”* In other words, David was grateful that God did not condemn him to Hades for his sin.
- **Psalm 86:13** — *“You have delivered my soul from the depths of Sheol.”*
- **Proverbs 15:24** — *“The path of life leads upward for the prudent, that he may turn away from Sheol beneath.”*
- **Isaiah 26:19** — *“Your dead shall live; their bodies shall rise. You who dwell in the dust, awake and sing for joy!”*
- **Daniel 12:2** — *“Many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt.”*

II. New Testament Passages on Descent and Ascent

Christ’s Descent and Ascent

- **Matthew 12:40** — *“For just as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the great fish, so will the Son of Man be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth.”*

- **Ephesians 4:9-10** — “In saying, ‘He ascended,’ what does it mean but that he had also descended into the lower regions, the earth?”
- **Acts 2:27, 31** — Peter quotes Psalm 16:10, applying it to Jesus: “You will not abandon my soul to Hades.”
- **Romans 10:6-7** — “Who will ascend into heaven?” or “Who will descend into the abyss?”
- **1 Peter 3:19** — “He went and proclaimed to the spirits in prison.”
- **1 Peter 4:6** — “The gospel was preached even to those who are dead.”

Resurrection and Ascension

- **John 3:13** — “No one has ascended into heaven except he who descended from heaven, the Son of Man.”
- **John 20:17** — Jesus says to Mary Magdalene, “I have not yet ascended to the Father.”
- **Acts 1:9-11** — Jesus is taken up into heaven; angels say he will come in the same way.
- **1 Thessalonians 4:16-17** — “The Lord himself will descend from heaven... and the dead in Christ will rise first.”
- **Revelation 20:13-14** — “The sea gave up the dead... Death and Hades gave up the dead... Then Death and Hades were thrown into the lake of fire.”

III. Final Thoughts on Sheol and Resurrection

When Christ rose from the dead, He was seen by many over a period of 40 days. He ate and drank, and Thomas put his fingers into Jesus' wounds. When Jesus rose from the dead, He was alone. And when Christ ascended, He was alone. The notion that people from Sheol joined him at either his resurrection or his ascension is not accurate.

Christ's resurrection was the firstfruits (conquering death, brought

back to life) — the first resurrection. The resurrection of the righteous (as heirs) spiritually in Christ's "first resurrection." However, from a futuristic perspective, by Jesus' conquering death and His resurrection, He was the first; His heirs will also be part of His first resurrection, even though it doesn't occur until the day of the Lord.

IV. The First Resurrection: A Two-Stage Reality

The First Resurrection is a two-stage fulfillment:

- Stage 1: Christ the Firstfruits, followed by
- Stage 2: The Righteous Dead, at His Second Coming

Until that Day, the righteous dead remain in Sheol's Paradise with the Tree of Life (God's Holy Spirit).

V. What Does "He Led Captives" Mean?

"But Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep."

— **1 Corinthians 15:20**

Thus, because He was first, 'He led' means He went *before* them in resurrection, not that He emptied Sheol of its righteous souls at that time.

"When He ascended on high, He led a host of captives..." — **Ephesians 4:8**

"But each in his own order: Christ the firstfruits, then at His coming those who belong to Christ."

— **1 Corinthians 15:23**

No righteous human has yet received what Christ now possesses — a resurrected, incorruptible body. The righteous dead and the "changed" alive will receive theirs on the day of the Lord, when we

rise UP from the surface to (apantesis) meet Him in the air as He is coming back to the earth. Why is He doing DOWN? To take possession of His kingdom — the Kingdom of God, the Kingdom of Heaven — which is here, on the earth. See v. 46 below: “...it is not the spiritual that is first, but the natural, and then the spiritual.” The “then the spiritual” are all the righteous souls-spirits awaiting their resurrection, which comes on the day of the Lord.

[42] “So is it with the resurrection of the dead. What is sown is perishable; what is raised is imperishable. [43] It is sown in dishonor; it is raised in glory. It is sown in weakness; it is raised in power. [44] It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body. If there is a natural body, there is also a spiritual body. [45] Thus it is written, ‘The first man Adam became a living being’; the last Adam became a life-giving spirit. [46] But it is not the spiritual that is first, but the natural, and then the spiritual. [47] The first man was from the earth, a man of dust; the second man is from heaven. [48] As was the man of dust, so also are those who are of the dust, and as is the man of heaven, so also are those who are of heaven. [49] Just as we have borne the image of the man of dust, we shall also bear the image of the man of heaven.”

— 1 Corinthians 15:42-49

[17] “Fear not, I am the first and the last, [18] and the living one. I died, and behold, I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades.”

— Revelation 1:17-18

(Jesus)



APPENDIX D - THE UP/DN SCRIPTURAL JOURNEY OF THE DEAD

These passages confirm a consistent biblical pattern: **the dead descend to Sheol** — the underworld — not *up* to Heaven.

When it was reported that Joseph was dead, Jacob expected to descend to Sheol, he said...

37 [35] *"I shall go **down** to Sheol to my son, mourning."*
— Genesis 37:35

Korah and his followers descended alive into Sheol...

16 [30-33] *"The earth opened its mouth and swallowed them up... and they went **down** alive into Sheol."*
— Numbers 16:30-33 paraphrased

Samuel was called up from his peaceful respite in Sheol's Paradise...

28 [10] *"Saul swore to her by the LORD, 'As the LORD lives, no punishment shall come upon you for this thing.' [11] Then the woman said, 'Whom shall I bring up to you?' Saul said, 'Bring up Samuel for me.' [12] When the*

woman saw Samuel, she cried out with a loud voice. And the woman said to Saul, 'Why have you deceived me? You are Saul.' [13] The king said to her, 'Do not be afraid. What to you see?' And the woman said to Saul, 'I see a god coming up out of the earth.' [14] Saul said to her, 'What is his appearance?' And she said, 'An old man is coming up, and he is wrapped in a robe.' And Saul knew that it was Samuel, and he bowed with his face to the ground and paid homage. [15] Then Samuel said to Saul, 'Why have you disturbed me by bringing me up?' Saul answered, 'I am in great distress...'"

— 1 Samuel 28:10-15

Lucifer will be cast down to the depths...

14 [9-15] "Sheol beneath is stirred up to meet you... You are brought **down** to Sheol, to the far reaches of the pit."

— Isaiah 14:9-15 paraphrased

Jesus Himself descended to the heart of the earth...

12 [40] "For just as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the great fish, so will the Son of Man be three days and three nights **in the heart of the earth.**"

— Matthew 12:40

While visiting the underworld, the patriarch Enoch (1 Enoch 22) is shown four distinct hollow places by the archangel Raphael. The chambers are separated according to the righteousness of the deceased.... There will be a resurrection of the condemned held in Hades when it's time for the great White Throne Judgment...

"For it is thou, O Lord, that hast power of life and death, and ledest down to the gates of death (Sheol's Paradise), and bringest back again (at the resurrection of the righteous)."

— Wisdom 16:13 (Catholic Bible, Apocrypha)

God poetically restored, forgave David by “bringing him up from Sheol”...

“O LORD, You have brought up my soul from Sheol; You restored me to life from among those who go down to the pit.”

— **Psalm 30:3**

Jesus descended to Sheol’s Paradise, then resurrected back to the surface, and then ascended into His heavenly abode...

“He descended into the lower parts of the earth. He who descended is the one who also ascended far above all the heavens.”

— **Ephesians 4:9-10**

Christ will descend from His heavenly abode to the surface of the earth one final time — the day of the Lord, when He returns to take possession of His Kingdom of God, on the earth...

“The Lord himself will descend from heaven... and the dead in Christ will rise first.”

— **1 Thessalonians 4:16-17**

The dead “in Christ” will rise *up* from Sheol, not fly down from Heaven. Likewise, the condemned in the sea and Hades will be resurrected to attend the great White Throne Judgment at the end of Christ’s millennial reign — and then it’s into the lake of fire for them...

*“The sea gave up the dead... Death and Hades gave **up** the dead who were in them.”*

— **Revelation 20:13-14**

The pattern is unmistakable: Death leads *down* to Sheol, and resurrection raises *up* to life on the surface of the earth — not to Heaven!



1. Genesis 37:35 — DOWN - Jacob expects to descend to Sheol.
2. Numbers 16:30-33 — DOWN - Korah and followers go down alive into Sheol.
3. Psalm 30:3 — UP - God brings David up from Sheol.
4. Isaiah 14:9-15 — DOWN - Lucifer is cast down to the depths.
5. Matthew 12:40 — DOWN - Jesus in the heart of the earth for 3
6. days.
7. Ephesians 4:9-10 — DOWN - He descended to Sheol's
8. Paradise, then resurrected UP to the surface, then He
9. ascended to the heavenly abode.
10. 1 Thessalonians 4:16 — DOWN - Lord descends, then UP to
11. the surface; the dead in Christ in Sheol's Paradise rise to the
12. surface.
13. Revelation 20:13 — UP — Hades gives UP the dead.
14. 1 Enoch 22 — DOWN - Sheol has hollowed places, Paradise for
15. the righteous vs. Hades for the wicked.
16. Wisdom 16:13 — DOWN - God leads to Hades, and then brings UP to the surface again.



APPENDIX E - THE TEMPLE IN GOD'S ABODE

The Temple in God's Abode

In the final chapters of Scripture, the heavenly realm is depicted with vivid imagery of temples, worship, and divine presence. These scenes reveal a profound mystery: even in the spiritual realms, the temple motif appears as a dwelling place of God's glory—an intersection of holiness and communion with His people.

Yet, the Book of Revelation shows that this temple is both present and, ultimately, transcended when God's eternal plan reaches its culmination.

The verses gathered in this appendix trace that unfolding mystery—illuminating the temple's role in God's "heavenly" abode and how it points us to a future where the Lord Himself will be our temple.

Ultimately, though, it appears that God will abandon His *shamayim* (Hebrew: "sky, the heavens") abode altogether when He delivers New Jerusalem down from "heaven" to the earth—when God's Holy City

becomes the eternal home where He and humanity commune together.

That will fulfill His original intent when He created the heavens and the earth — His “mountain of God” for the *elohim* and His divine council, and the garden of Eden and the rest of the planet for His second family—Adam’s progeny.

Let these passages draw you into the wonder of God’s eternal presence and the promise that one day, “the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb” will be the only temple we need.

This divine arc underscores God’s abiding desire to dwell with humanity — the very purpose for which God placed Adam in the garden in the first place.

God’s final dwelling with humanity in New Jerusalem on the earth underscores the culmination of His redemptive plan — a progression seen in these verses: from His heavenly throne on the ‘mountain of God,’ to the tent of witness during the Exodus, to Jesus enthroned on Mount Zion during the millennium, and finally to New Jerusalem itself.

[9] “After this I looked, and behold, a great multitude that no one could number, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages, standing before the throne and before the Lamb, clothed in white robes, with palm branches in their hands, [10] and crying out with a loud voice, ‘Salvation belongs to our God who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb!’ [11] And all the angels were standing around the throne and around the elders and the four living creatures, and they fell on their faces before the throne and worshiped God, [12] saying, ‘Amen! Blessing and glory and wisdom and thanksgiving and honor and power and might be to our God forever and ever! Amen.’ [13] Then one of the elders addressed me, saying, ‘Who are these, clothed in white robes, and from where have they come?’ [14] I said to him, ‘Sir, you know.’ And he said to me, ‘These are the ones coming out

of the great tribulation. They have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb. [15] 'Therefore, they are before the throne of God, and serve Him day and night in His temple; and He who sits on the throne will shelter them with His presence. ...[17] for the Lamb in the midst of the throne will be their shepherd, and He will guide them to springs of living water, and God will wipe away every tear from their eyes.'

— Revelation 7:9-17

[15b] "The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of His Christ, and He shall reign forever and ever.' [16] And the twenty-four elders who sit on their thrones before God fell on their faces and worshiped God, [17] saying, 'We give thanks to you, Lord God Almighty, who is and who was, for you have taken your great power and begun to reign. [18] The nations raged, but your wrath came, and the time for the dead to be judged, and for rewarding your servants, the prophets and saints, and those who fear your name, both small and great, and for destroying the destroyers of the earth.' [19] Then God's temple in heaven was opened, and the ark of His covenant was seen within His temple. There were flashes of lightning, rumblings, peals of thunder, an earthquake, and heavy hail."

— Revelation 11:15b-19

(The 7th Trumpet)

[5] "After this, I looked, and the sanctuary of the tent of witness in heaven was opened, [6] and out of the sanctuary came the seven angels with the seven plagues, clothed in pure, bright linen, with golden sashes around their chests...and no one could enter the sanctuary until the seven plagues of the seven angels were finished"

— Revelation 15:5-6

(7 angels with seven plagues - Bowls of God's [orge] wrath)

"And I saw no temple in the city, for its temple is the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb."

— Revelation 21:22

READING & RESEARCH GUIDE

FOR DIGGING DEEPER INTO ANCIENT WORLDVIEWS, SHEOL'S REALM, AND THE COSMIC ORDER

This brief guide recommends trusted sources and scholars whose work can help you explore the biblical worldview of life, death, and the eternal Kingdom of God. It's designed to illuminate the ancient roots of the Tree of Life, Sheol's Paradise, and the cosmic drama that surrounds them.

1. George Syncellus, *Chronography (Ekloge Chronographias)*

The 9th-century Byzantine monk preserved ancient chronologies going back to the Creation. His work is a treasure for those curious about pre-Abrahamic worldviews.

2. James Ussher, *The Annals of the World* (1658)

Ussher's chronology—spanning Creation to the early centuries AD—remains a standard framework for biblical and ancient history studies.

3. Eusebius, *Chronicle and Church History*

Eusebius' chronicle work preserves ancient Near Eastern and early Christian views of the past. His texts were major sources for Syncellus.

4. Jack Finegan, *Handbook of Biblical Chronology*

A modern classic. Finegan compares biblical data with ancient Near Eastern records, helping readers harmonize timelines.

5. Michael S. Heiser, *The Unseen Realm & Reversing Hermon*

Heiser's work is invaluable for understanding the "divine council," Sheol, and the spiritual cosmos of the Bible.

6. John H. Walton, *Ancient Near Eastern Thought and the Old Testament*

Walton offers clear insights into how the ancient world understood Sheol, Paradise, and cosmic geography.

7. Alfred Jeremias, *Handbuch der Altorientalischen Geisteskultur* (1913)

Though older, Jeremias' work remains a rich summary of the ancient Near East's religious beliefs and cosmic architecture.

8. N.T. Wright, *The Day the Revolution Began & Surprised by Hope*

Wright's works focus on resurrection and hope, key to understanding why Paradise awaits the righteous.

9. Robert Drews, *The End of the Bronze Age*

This work provides helpful context for the great cultural shifts of the ancient Near East—even as it sits downstream of Abraham's time.

10. K.A. Kitchen, *On the Reliability of the Old Testament*

Kitchen's work bridges archaeology and biblical testimony—especially around the patriarchs and the Exodus.

The Tree of Life is a signpost for God's Spirit and His Kingdom to come.

GLOSSARY OF KEY BIBLICAL TERMS

Glossary of Key Terms

- **Covenant** – A sacred agreement or bond initiated by God, forming the relational framework of His redemptive plan across history.
- **Eden** – The original garden sanctuary where God dwelled with humanity. Not merely a location, but a prototype of divine presence on Earth.
- **Exile** – Humanity's separation from God's presence due to sin. The core problem that the biblical narrative seeks to resolve.
- **Glorification** – The final stage of salvation when believers are resurrected and transformed into immortal, incorruptible bodies like Christ's.
- **Image of God** – The unique identity of humanity as representatives of God's character and authority on Earth. Not lost in the Fall, but marred and awaiting restoration.
- **Kingdom of God** – God's active reign on Earth through His Messiah, culminating in the Day of the Lord and the restoration of all things.

- **New Jerusalem** – The final, restored dwelling place of God with humanity. A garden-city where the Tree of Life reappears and the curse is lifted.
- **Paradise** – In Second Temple thought, the righteous dead awaited resurrection in the blessed part of Sheol. Jesus told the thief, “Today you will be with Me in Paradise.”
- **Priest-King** – A blended role pointing to Adam, Melchizedek, David, and ultimately Jesus — and now extended to the redeemed, who will reign with Him.
- **Shamar** – Hebrew for “keep” or “guard,” used of Adam’s duty in Eden and the priest’s role in the tabernacle. A sacred charge to protect God’s space.
- **Sheol** – The Hebrew term for the realm of the dead. Not hell, but a shadowed waiting place divided between the righteous and the wicked.
- **Tree of Life** – Both a literal and symbolic tree representing divine life, immortality, and union with God. Found in Eden, Calvary, and Revelation.

INTRODUCTION TO BIBLE LINGUISTICS

Linguistics is the scientific study of language. Several years ago, I imagined that ancient Hebrew was most likely the language God and the angels speak.

I had all sorts of charts and graphs, as well as red yarn strands crisscrossing an entire wall in a bedroom. I learned a great deal about the relationships between languages, but ultimately, I was unable to make a definitive declaration.

So, if you ever encounter an angel, you might ask him about his native language. Then, please send me an email and let me know what he said.

The Septuagint (LXX) is a Greek *translation* of the Hebrew Bible. However, the Masoretic Text (MT) is *the* authoritative Hebrew text. It's essential to recognize this distinction.

When writing the books in The Restoration Series and conducting my day-to-day studies, I have found Biblehub.com to be an excellent resource for testing English version translations.

Ironically, I have discovered the King James Version is the *least* accurate English translation and the source of many controversies. Sadly, too many Americans **assume** the KJV is the most accurate.



EPILOGUE

We began in a garden. We will end up in a garden city.
And all the while, the Tree — God's Shekhinah
witnessed our fall, our redemption, and our restoration.

The story of Scripture is God's redemption and restoration of
humanity.

It's about the love of a Father who planted a garden not only to
delight the eye but to dwell among His children.

It's about a Son who hung on a Tree so we could be grafted in as
branches — some wild, and some cultivated.

The Tree of Life — what more can be said than what has been
reported in this book?

It is alive in Christ.

It is promised to the faithful.

It is rooted in our future resurrection.

We were made for Eden.

We were exiled by sin.

But now, we are oaks of righteousness, a people preparing to reign.

Let this not be the end of your reading, but the beginning of your restoration.

Study the Scriptures.

Seek the Lord.

Bear the fruit of the Tree whose roots will sustain us throughout eternity.

And its leaves are for the healing of the nations.



ABOUT THE AUTHOR



I was raised in a Roman Catholic home—the eldest of five children, educated at a Catholic parochial school through eighth grade, and shaped by a family whose faith was sincere, disciplined, and devoted. My father, a Presbyterian, agreed to have his children raised Catholic as a condition of marrying my mother. That decision profoundly influenced my early spiritual formation.

Similarly, my wife was raised in the Catholic and Lutheran traditions. We raised our sons within a non-denominational evangelical Christian framework, prioritizing Christ-centered education and discipleship over denominational allegiance.

I trained as a surgeon and served as a medical missionary in Papua New Guinea, China, East Africa, and the North Africa & Middle East regions. I was fortunate to have combined gospel-driven compassion with practical service.

What began as a lifelong personal pursuit of biblical clarity has

grown into a focused mission: to help believers understand what God truly revealed in the Bible. I write today as a follower of Jesus Christ—not in the modern denominational sense, but in the biblical one. I believe in one Christian faith, whispered to the prophets, taught by Jesus and His apostles, and faithfully preserved in their original-language Hebrew, Greek, and Aramaic Testaments.

— *Tim*

AFTERWORD

If you've reached this point, you've done something rare: you've paused to examine not just what you believe — but why.

This volume is only the beginning. *The Restoration Series* continues with books on resurrection, covenant, Christ's return, and the fulfillment of God's plan.

We're reading with open eyes and recovering the gospel the prophets and apostles taught — with hope, clarity, and allegiance to Jesus, the soon-returning King.

— *Dr. Tim James*

BACK COVER BLURB

Tree of Life is the second book in The Restoration Series. From the Mountain of God and the Garden of Eden to Sheol and the Paradise of God, this book takes you on a journey to the Parousia of our King on the Day of the Lord—culminating in eternity with God in the New Jerusalem.

Tree of Life unveils God's Spirit and challenges long-held assumptions shaped by faulty English translations of the original Greek and Hebrew. This book is for scholars, seminarians, pastors, and earnest seekers—anyone yearning to discover biblical truth with fresh clarity, allegiance, and hope.

Jesus came. He's coming again!

Are you ready for what the Scriptures truly reveal?